

# Curved Scroll

Shadowdark Zine 2: Red Sands

#2

DESERT SORCERERS!

BANDITS!

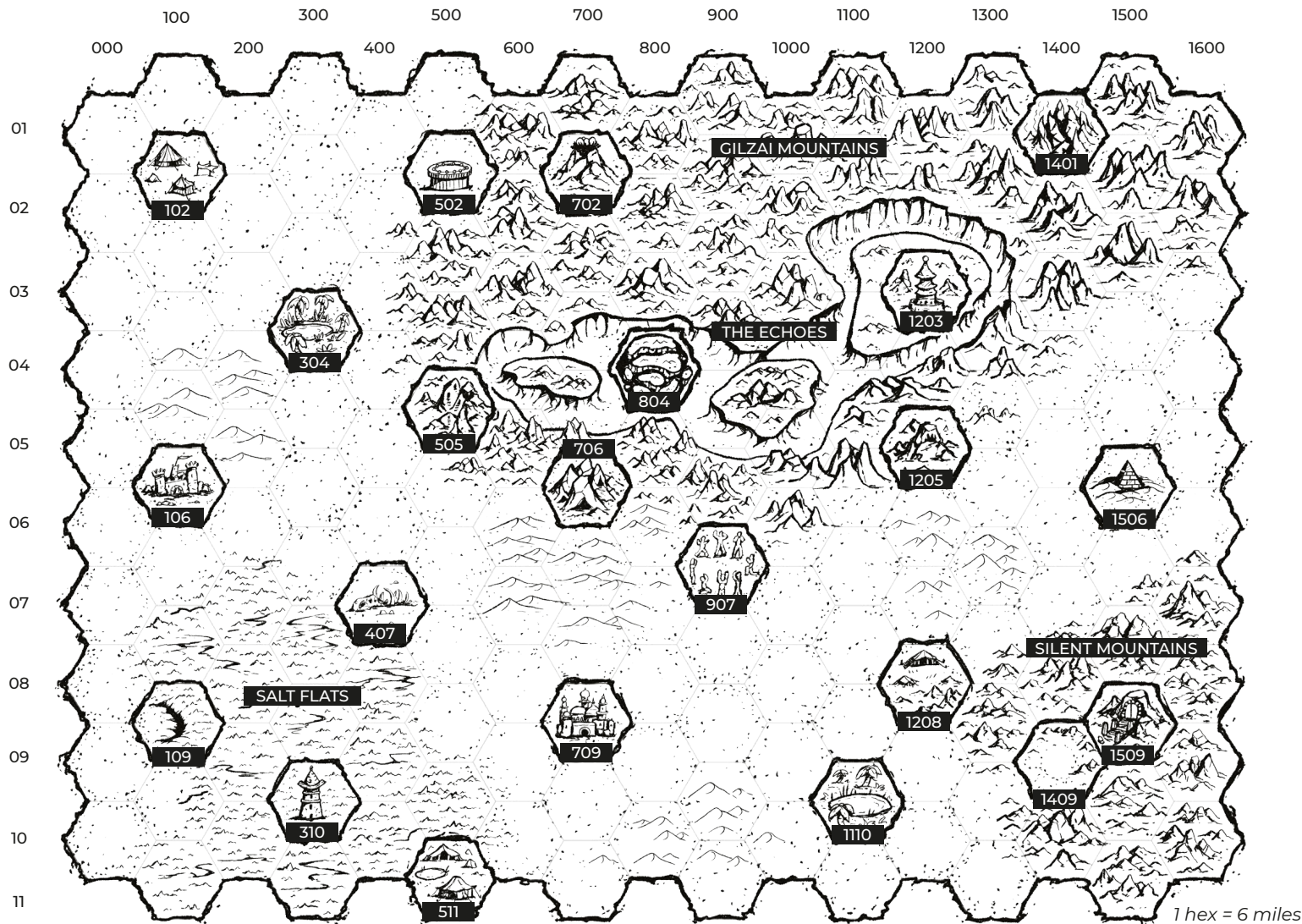
LOST TREASURES!

RUINS!

PIT FIGHTS!

PERILOUS ADVENTURES!





A miniature hexcrawl featuring

# The Djurum

A vast, shimmering desert where red mountains stand silent watch over windblown valleys and undulating sand dunes. Merchant caravans pick their way between fragile oases that dot the wastes, hoping to miss the path of mountain bandits, a howling sandstorm, or the skyborn death of **The Scourge**. Here, efreet-haunted canyons hide the ancient redoubt of the **Ras-Godai** assassins, and priceless secrets lie buried, waiting for the winds to shift in their favor...

## ENCOUNTER ZONE

| d8 | Desert | Canyon | Mountain | Salt Flat |
|----|--------|--------|----------|-----------|
| 1  | Flier  | Flier  | Flier    | Flier     |
| 2  | Digger | Flier  | Flier    | Digger    |
| 3  | Digger | Flier  | Flier    | Digger    |
| 4  | Digger | Walker | Flier    | Walker    |
| 5  | Walker | Walker | Flier    | Walker    |
| 6  | Walker | Walker | Walker   | Walker    |
| 7  | People | Walker | Walker   | People    |
| 8  | People | People | People   | People    |

See pg. 33 for **The Djurum's** hex key!

*\*New monsters, pg. 39*

## RUMORS

- 1 A giant eagle of pure fire dwells in the Gilzai Mountains
- 2 A fortress full of gold lies deep inside the Howling Caves
- 3 Mountain bandits watch for travelers coming from the oases
- 4 An efreeti haunts the winding maze of trails inside The Echoes
- 5 The top of a buried pyramid rises from the sands to the east
- 6 An ancient dragon called The Scourge lairs in the Gilzai crags
- 7 The Ras-Godai assassins train in a hidden canyon monastery
- 8 Purple worms have a spawning ground in the west salt flats
- 9 Elves raise prized silver camels in a camp to the northwest
- 10 A lost city lies beyond the great doors in the Vale of the Moon

## ENCOUNTERS

| d8 | Walker           | Flier        | Digger       | People         |
|----|------------------|--------------|--------------|----------------|
| 1  | Rakshasa         | The Scourge* | Purple worm  | 1d8 Ras-Godai* |
| 2  | Naga             | Efreeti      | 2d4 ankheg   | 3d6 bandit     |
| 3  | 2d4 gt. scorpion | Manticore    | Bulette      | Peasant        |
| 4  | 1d8 dunefiend*   | 2d12 vulture | Bone naga    | 2d4 siruul*    |
| 5  | 1d6 cobra        | Dust devil*  | 2d4 scorpion | Mage           |
| 6  | Oni, 1d6 bandit  | Djinni       | 3d6 skeleton | 2d4 thief      |
| 7  | Canyon ape*      | Ghost        | Mummy        | Gladiator      |
| 8  | Mirage*          | Phoenix      | Mirage*      | Caravan†       |

†2d20 peasants (L), 1:6 disguised rakshasa (C)



# Cursed Scroll

## WRITING, DESIGN, DUNGEON CARTOGRAPHY, LAYOUT

Kelsey Dionne. Enduring Wounds rules and table (pg. 26)  
adapted with permission from design by **Zion Kurtz**, 2022.

## ART

**Hex cartography** by Cameron Maas. **Thraxis Arena** cartography by Jesse Egan. **Trade dress** by Brandish Gilhelm. Some artwork © Blake Davis / Art of Blake, used with permission. Some art by Warm\_Tail, Evgeny Turaev, Ponksak14, and Anna\_Illustrator / shutterstock.com. Pit Fighter and Gladiator artwork © Richard Sampson (NerdGore), used with permission. Some artwork © 2022 Eric Lofgren, used with permission. All rights reserved. Dragon artwork © Indi Martin, 2022. Some artwork © 2015 Dean Spencer, used with permission. All rights reserved. Some artwork Publisher's Choice Quality Stock Art © Rick Hershey / Fat Goblin Games.

## FONTS

JSL Blackletter font © Jeffrey S. Lee. Old Newspaper Types font © Manfred Klein. Fullteron font © Emyself Design. Montserrat font family © Julieta Ulanovsky, Sol Matas, Juan Pablo del Peral, Jacques Le Bailly.

## LEGAL INFORMATION AND ATTRIBUTION STATEMENT

Not for resale or redistribution. Permission granted to print or copy for personal use only. *Shadowdark RPG* © The Arcane Library, LLC. This work includes material taken from the System Reference Document 5.1 ("SRD 5.1") by Wizards of the Coast LLC and available at <https://dnd.wizards.com/resources/systems-reference-document>. The SRD 5.1 is licensed under the Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International License available at <https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/legalcode>.



THE ARCANES LIBRARY

## ShadowDark



# Contents



|                           |           |                                             |           |
|---------------------------|-----------|---------------------------------------------|-----------|
| <b>The Djurum Hex Map</b> | <b>2</b>  | Enduring Wounds                             | 26        |
| The Djurum Encounters     | 3         | Poisons                                     | 27        |
| <b>Contents</b>           | <b>6</b>  | Mounts                                      | 28        |
| Introduction              | 7         | <b>The Djurum</b>                           | <b>31</b> |
| <b>Characters</b>         | <b>9</b>  | Travel In The Sands                         | 32        |
| Desert Rider              | 10        | The Djurum Hex Key                          | 33        |
| Pit Fighter               | 12        | <b>Monsters</b>                             | <b>39</b> |
| Ras-Godai                 | 14        | <b>Fortress of the Burning Brothers</b>     | <b>45</b> |
| Titles                    | 16        | Overview                                    | 46        |
| New Weapons               | 17        | Iron Fortress ( Areas 1-19)                 | 48        |
| <b>Gameplay</b>           | <b>19</b> | Mines (Areas 20-35)                         | 56        |
| Pit Fighting              | 20        | <b>In A Dead Bandit's Hand, You Find...</b> | <b>68</b> |
| Pit Fighting Encounters   | 22        |                                             |           |
| Thraxis Arena             | 24        |                                             |           |

# Introduction

**T**he second issue of *Cursed Scroll* arrives on a scorching, desert wind!

This time, we explore an undulating sea of sand, where vibrant camel caravans pick their way across moonlike valleys, and far-eyed bandits peer down from their clifftop perches like birds of prey.

These are the lands where the fearsome ~~Kas-Codai~~ sorcerers train in hidden canyon monasteries, perfecting the art of dealing unseen death.

Here, the whipping sandstorms scour flesh from bone. And in their aftermath, forgotten places emerge at long last from beneath the endless sand, calling **crawlers** to tempt their fates inside sinister, secret-filled halls.

As ever, the contents of this zine are fully compatible with the **Shadowdark RPG** rules. The free Quickstart Set is available for download at [thearcanelibrary.com/pages/shadowdark](http://thearcanelibrary.com/pages/shadowdark).

So unfurl this strange, crumbling scroll you found in a dead bandit's hand and read as far as you dare! Its secrets might haunt you, might curse you, might send you chasing unimaginable treasures and fighting incredible foes. And when the sands run **red** with blood, whose will it be?

As they say in this place of cruelty and myth:

**May the stories they tell of  
you outnumber all the grains  
of sand before us!**

-Kelsey Dionne, Oct. 2022



# Characters

---



**"It is through trials of blood, fire, and terror that  
you will find the wellspring of your power."**

**-Manazusa, leader of the Ras-Godai**

# Desert Rider Class

Howling barbarians thundering across the sand on wild horses, elven spies wielding curved blades atop silvery camels, or bandits wrapped in colorful silks racing on sleek, desert stallions.

**Weapons:** Club, dagger, javelin, longsword, pike (see New Weapons, pg. 17), shortbow, scimitar, spear, whip

**Armor:** Leather armor, shields

**Hit Points:** 1d8 per level

**Charge.** 3/day, you can charge into combat by moving at least near before attacking. Each time you do this, your melee attacks deal double damage that round.

**Mount.** You have a common camel or horse with a reliable or lovely demeanor (see pg. 29). It comes when you call and never spooks. You can only have one such mount at a time.

While riding your mount, you both get a bonus to AC equal to half your level (round down). Your mount has additional levels equal to half your level (round down). You can freely leap on or off your mount once per round.

If you lose your mount, you can use your downtime to acquire and train another. Pass a DC 15 CHA check for the new creature to become your mount. Lower the DC one step each attempt.



## DESERT RIDER TALENTS

| 2d6 | Effect (2 duplicate = reroll) |
|-----|-------------------------------|
|-----|-------------------------------|

|   |                                                      |
|---|------------------------------------------------------|
| 2 | You can use any rider-bearing creature as your mount |
|---|------------------------------------------------------|

|     |                                  |
|-----|----------------------------------|
| 3-6 | You gain +1 to attacks or damage |
|-----|----------------------------------|

|     |                                                          |
|-----|----------------------------------------------------------|
| 7-9 | +2 to Strength or Dexterity stat, or +1 to melee attacks |
|-----|----------------------------------------------------------|

|       |                                                       |
|-------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| 10-11 | Gain an additional use of your Charge talent each day |
|-------|-------------------------------------------------------|

|    |                                                       |
|----|-------------------------------------------------------|
| 12 | Choose one option or +2 points to distribute to stats |
|----|-------------------------------------------------------|



# Pit Fighter Class

Blood-soaked warriors circling each other in a roaring arena, scarred desert bandits dueling for the right to lead their gang, or brash tavern brawlers who never turn down a challenge.

**Weapons:** All weapons

**Armor:** Leather armor, shields

**Hit Points:** 1d8 per level

**Flourish.** 3/day, regain 1d6 hit points when you hit an enemy with a melee attack.

**Implacable.** You have advantage on Constitution checks to resist injury, poison, or endure extreme environments.

**Last Stand.** You get up from dying with 1 hit point on a natural d20 roll of 18-20.

**Relentless.** 3/day, when you are reduced to 0 HP, make a DC 18 Constitution check (the Implacable talent applies to this roll). On a success, you instead go to 1 HP.

## PIT FIGHTER TALENTS

| 2d6   | Effect (2 duplicate = additional use per day)               |
|-------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2     | 1/day, ignore all damage and effects from one attack        |
| 3-6   | You gain +1 to melee weapon damage                          |
| 7-9   | +2 to Strength or Constitution stat, or +1 to melee attacks |
| 10-11 | Increase the HP you gain from Flourish by 1d6               |
| 12    | Choose one option or +2 points to distribute to stats       |

**"It's over when I SAY it's over!"**  
-Markesh, human pit fighter



# Ras-Godai Class

Black-clad assassins who train from childhood inside a hidden desert monastery. They gain their sorcerous powers from a legendary black lotus flower that was given to them by a demon.

**Weapons:** Blowgun, (see pg. 17), bolas, dagger, razor chain, scimitar, shuriken, spear

**Armor:** Leather armor

**Hit Points:** 1d6 per level

**Languages.** You know Diabolic.

**Assassinate.** When you attack a surprised target, you deal double damage against it.

**Smoke Step.** 3/day, teleport to a location you can see within near. This does not use your action.

**Black Lotus.** You earned the right to eat a petal of the fabled black lotus flower, and you survived its sorcerous effects.

Roll one talent on the Black Lotus Talents table. You may reroll duplicates or keep them.



## RAS-GODAI TALENTS

### 2d6 (2 duplicate = reroll)

- |       |                                                            |
|-------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2     | You are trained in the use of poisons (see pg. 27)         |
| 3-6   | Roll an additional talent on the Black Lotus Talents table |
| 7-9   | +2 to Strength or Dexterity stat, or +1 to melee attacks   |
| 10-11 | Gain an additional use of your Smoke Step talent           |
| 12    | Choose one option or +2 points to distribute to stats      |

## BLACK LOTUS TALENTS

### d12 Details

- |    |                                                                                                                                 |
|----|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1  | You deal triple damage with your Assassinate talent                                                                             |
| 2  | 1/day, paralyze a target of LV 9 or less you damage with a weapon for 1d4 rounds                                                |
| 3  | You have advantage on Dexterity checks to avoid entrapment or injury                                                            |
| 4  | You gain +1 to your AC when wielding a melee weapon in each hand                                                                |
| 5  | You gain an additional hit points die                                                                                           |
| 6  | You have advantage on Dexterity checks to hide                                                                                  |
| 7  | When enemies who can see you make a morale check, the DC is 18 instead of 15                                                    |
| 8  | 1/day, you can walk on water as if it were solid for 1d4 rds                                                                    |
| 9  | 1/day, choose a living creature of LV 5 or less you can see within near; it must pass a DC 15 CON check or fall asleep          |
| 10 | 1/day, you can walk on sheer surfaces like walls for 1d4 rds                                                                    |
| 11 | You deal +1 damage with melee weapons                                                                                           |
| 12 | 1/day, choose a creature of LV 9 or less you can see; it must pass a DC 15 WIS check or it can't see or hear you for 1d4 rounds |

# Titles

## DESERT RIDER TITLES

| Level | Lawful      | Chaotic           | Neutral |
|-------|-------------|-------------------|---------|
| 1-2   | Outrider    | Bandit            | Rat     |
| 3-4   | Sandrunner  | Robber            | Fox     |
| 5-6   | Trailblazer | Raider            | Wolf    |
| 7-8   | Swift Wind  | Scourge           | Tiger   |
| 9-10  | Stormrunner | Bandit King/Queen | Dragon  |

## PIT FIGHTER TITLES

| Level | Lawful    | Chaotic | Neutral    |
|-------|-----------|---------|------------|
| 1-2   | Rookie    | Ruffian | Underdog   |
| 3-4   | Gladiator | Brawler | Dark Horse |
| 5-6   | Hero      | Heel    | Wild Card  |
| 7-8   | Champion  | Villain | Victor     |
| 9-10  | Legend    | Legend  | Legend     |

## RAS-GODAI TITLES

| Level | Lawful      | Chaotic     | Neutral     |
|-------|-------------|-------------|-------------|
| 1-2   | Acolyte     | Acolyte     | Acolyte     |
| 3-4   | Mirror Path | Shadow Path | Fire Path   |
| 5-6   | Monk        | Monk        | Monk        |
| 7-8   | Master      | Assassin    | Demon Blade |
| 9-10  | White Lotus | Black Lotus | Red Lotus   |

# New Weapons

## NEW WEAPONS

| Weapon      | Cost  | Type | Range | Damage  | Properties  |
|-------------|-------|------|-------|---------|-------------|
| Blowgun     | 5 gp  | R    | N     | 1       | See below   |
| Bolas       | 2 gp  | R    | N     | -       | See below   |
| Morningstar | 5 gp  | M    | C     | 1d6/1d8 | V           |
| Pike        | 10 gp | M    | 2x C  | 1d10    | 2H, 2 slots |
| Razor chain | 12 gp | M/R  | N     | 1d6     | F, La       |
| Scimitar    | 8 gp  | M    | C     | 1d6     | F           |
| Shuriken    | 1 gp  | R    | N     | 1d4     | See below   |
| Sling       | 5 sp  | R    | F     | 1d4     | -           |
| Whip        | 10 gp | M/R  | N     | 1d4     | F, La       |

**Finesse (F).** You can use your Strength or Dexterity when attacking with this weapon.

**Lash (La).** When you make a ranged attack with this weapon, it does not leave your grasp.

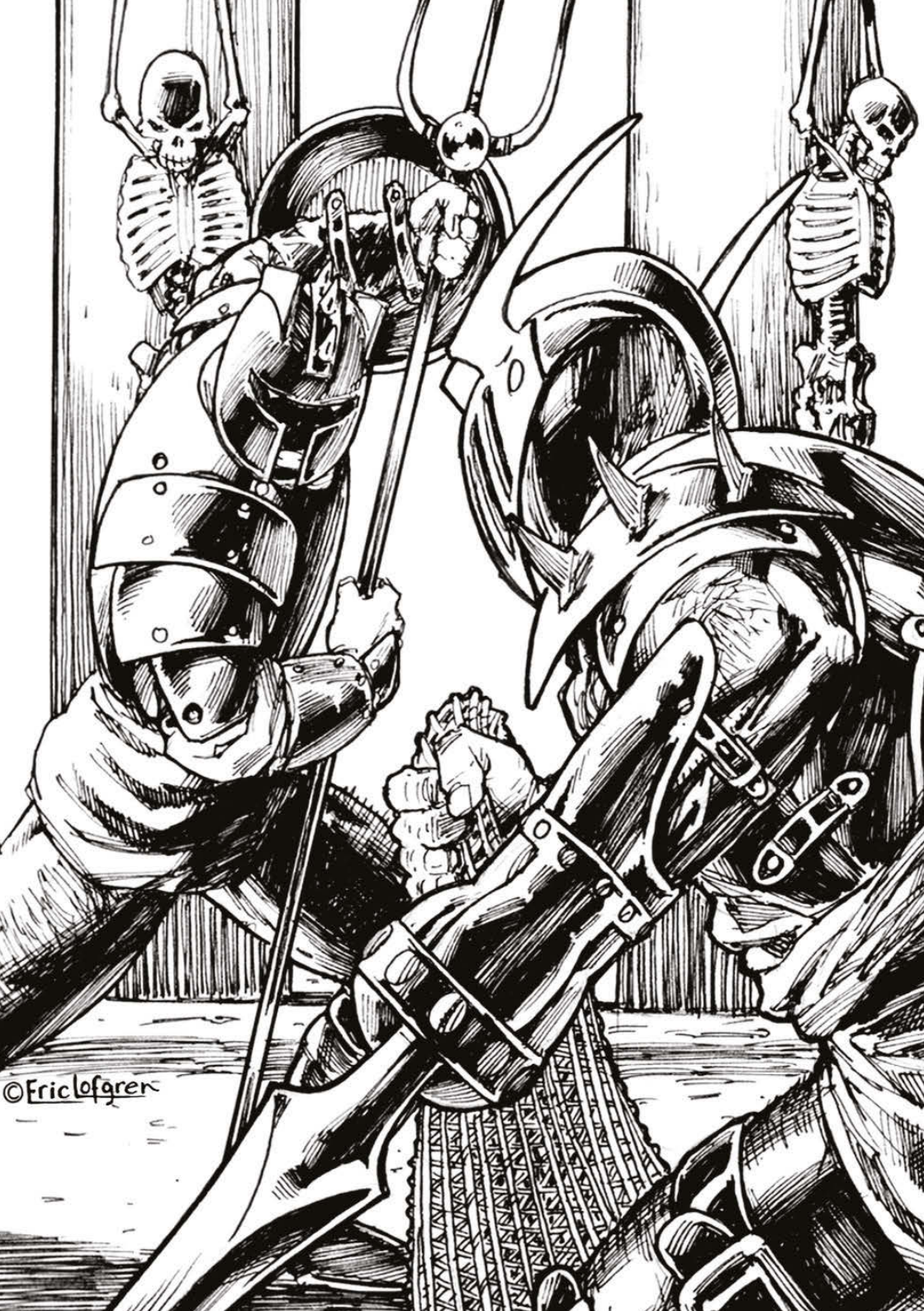
**Two-handed (2H).** You must use this weapon with two hands.

**Versatile (V).** You can use this weapon with one or two hands. Use the higher damage die if you're wielding it with two.

**Blowgun.** Firing this weapon from hiding doesn't reveal your position.

**Bolas.** When you hit a legged creature the size of a horse or smaller, the target's speed is reduced to close until it frees itself (DC 15 STR or DEX check).

**Shuriken.** Can be thrown into the ground. Living creatures who step on it take 1 damage and can only move at half speed for 10 rounds.

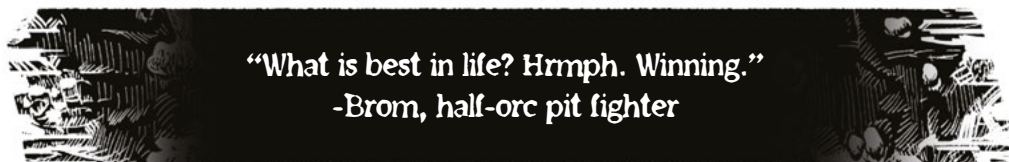


# Gameplay

---



“What is best in life? Hrmph. Winning.”  
-Brom, half-orc pit fighter



# Pit Fighting

During downtime, PCs can participate in pit fights to gain treasure, experience, and fame.

**Lethality.** The lethality of the fight depends on the venue and stakes. Killing humanoids is forbidden in most public venues.

Pit fighting is not without risks; Game Masters might use the Enduring Wounds table (pg. 26) for vicious injuries.

## SETTING UP A BOUT

Roll on the **Venue** and **Stakes** tables for an available pit fight. Groups of PCs use their Average Party Level (**APL**) for stakes rolls.

Based on the venue and stakes, the GM decides the danger level and foe (see Pit Fight Encounters, pg. 22) and shares those details.

Then, the fighters decide to **accept** or **decline** the bout. Fighters who break their word risk losing future bout offers.

## DANGER LEVEL

**Low.** Low stakes or a safe venue. Fight to half HP or knockout. The GM uses the **Low Stakes Pit Fight** encounter tables.

**Mid.** Mid stakes or a moderately risky venue. Fight to knockout or, on rare occasion, death. The GM uses the **Mid Stakes Pit Fight** encounter tables.

**High.** High/epic stakes or an extreme/rare venue. Fight to the death is common. The GM uses the **High/Epic Stakes Pit Fight** encounter tables.

## TWIST

The GM secretly checks whether a surprise twist occurs that is revealed during the bout.

## RESULTS

The winners get the stakes (see **Shadowdark RPG** for treasure tables) and resulting XP. Some NPC relationships or rivalries may also change as a result.

## VENUE

| 2d6  | Venue                                      |
|------|--------------------------------------------|
| 2-4  | Shady back alley or tavern cellar at night |
| 5-7  | Cage fight, small arena                    |
| 8-10 | Open-air, large arena                      |
| 11   | Luxurious private arena owned by a noble   |
| 12   | Glorious coliseum                          |

## STAKES

| APL + 1d6 | Stakes |
|-----------|--------|
| 2-5       | Low    |
| 6-10      | Mid    |
| 11-13     | High   |
| 14+       | Epic   |

## TWIST

| 2d6   | Details                                                                                                                                  |
|-------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2-5   | Additional danger.<br>1d4: <b>1.</b> Trap, <b>2.</b> Hazard, <b>3.</b> Unexpected foe, <b>4.</b> Banned resources (armor, weapon, spell) |
| 6-9   | None                                                                                                                                     |
| 10-11 | A donor increases the stakes by one level                                                                                                |
| 12    | An attendee throws a useful boon, item, or spell to the fighters during the bout                                                         |

## LOW STAKES

| d4 | Bout Is For...          |
|----|-------------------------|
| 1  | 20 gp                   |
| 2  | Small favor from NPC    |
| 3  | +2 on next carouse roll |
| 4  | 20-100 on Treasure 0-3  |

## MID STAKES

| d4 | Bout Is For...          |
|----|-------------------------|
| 1  | 50 gp                   |
| 2  | Big favor from NPC      |
| 3  | +3 on next carouse roll |
| 4  | 50-100 on Treasure 4-6  |

## HIGH STAKES

| d4 | Bout Is For...          |
|----|-------------------------|
| 1  | 100 gp                  |
| 2  | Favor from royalty      |
| 3  | +4 on next carouse roll |
| 4  | 70-100 on Treasure 7-9  |

## EPIC STAKES

| d4 | Bout Is For...              |
|----|-----------------------------|
| 1  | A giant diamond             |
| 2  | The <i>wish</i> of a djinni |
| 3  | +5 on next carouse roll     |
| 4  | 80-100 on Treasure 10+      |

# Pit Fighting Encounters

## LOW STAKES PIT FIGHT (SOLO)

| d6 | Creature 1    | Creature 2    | Complication |
|----|---------------|---------------|--------------|
| 1  | Lion          | Lion          | 10' deep pit |
| 2  | Rookie*       | Bandit        | Spiked nets  |
| 3  | Soldier       | Gt. centipede | Burning oil  |
| 4  | Thug          | —             | —            |
| 5  | Gt. centipede | —             | —            |
| 6  | Bandit        | —             | —            |

## LOW STAKES PIT FIGHT (GROUP)

| d6 | Creature 1 | Creature 2  | Complication |
|----|------------|-------------|--------------|
| 1  | 6 bandit   | Cobra snake | 10' deep pit |
| 2  | 6 thug     | Gladiator   | Spiked nets  |
| 3  | 2 rookie*  | 3 lion      | Burning oil  |
| 4  | Berserker  | Cultist     | —            |
| 5  | Hero*      | 2 rookie    | —            |
| 6  | Ankheg     | —           | —            |

## MID STAKES PIT FIGHT (SOLO)

| d6 | Creature 1  | Creature 2   | Complication     |
|----|-------------|--------------|------------------|
| 1  | 2 lion      | 2 gt. frog   | Water hazards    |
| 2  | 2 ankheg    | Gt. scorpion | No gear to start |
| 3  | 2 hero*     | 2 lion       | 30' deep pits    |
| 4  | Knight      | —            | Rolling boulders |
| 5  | 4 rookie*   | —            | —                |
| 6  | 2 berserker | —            | —                |

## MID STAKES PIT FIGHT (GROUP)

| d8 | Creature 1     | Creature 2     | Complication     |
|----|----------------|----------------|------------------|
| 1  | Basilisk       | Mage           | Water hazards    |
| 2  | Elephant       | Ogre           | No gear to start |
| 3  | 3 gladiator    | 2 ankheg       | 30' deep pits    |
| 4  | 4 gt. scorpion | 3 gladiator    | Rolling boulders |
| 5  | Hippopotamus   | Reaver         | Chained to post  |
| 6  | Rhinoceros     | 4 cobra snake  | Capture the flag |
| 7  | Gt. snake      | 2 rust monster | —                |
| 8  | Gt. crab       | —              | —                |

## HIGH/EPIC STAKES PIT FIGHT (SOLO)

| d6 | Creature 1    | Creature 2       | Complication    |
|----|---------------|------------------|-----------------|
| 1  | Minotaur      | Wyvern (chained) | Antimagic zones |
| 2  | Ogre          | 4 gladiator      | 60' deep pits   |
| 3  | Canyon ape    | Mage             | Spiked boulders |
| 4  | Rival crawler | —                | Fire jets       |
| 5  | Reaver        | —                | —               |
| 6  | 2 basilisk    | —                | —               |

## HIGH/EPIC STAKES PIT FIGHT (GROUP)

| d8 | Creature 1         | Creature 2          | Complication      |
|----|--------------------|---------------------|-------------------|
| 1  | Archmage           | Bulette             | Over a fatal fall |
| 2  | Hydra (6 heads)    | 4 mage              | Flooded arena     |
| 3  | 2d4 rival crawlers | 2 canyon ape        | Antimagic zones   |
| 4  | 6 hero*            | Tyrannosaurus       | 60' deep pits     |
| 5  | Stone golem        | 3 reaver            | Spiked boulders   |
| 6  | Cyclops            | Wyvern (chained)    | Fire jets         |
| 7  | 2 roper            | Manticore (chained) | —                 |
| 8  | 4 rust monster     | —                   | —                 |

# Thraxis Arena

A broad, flat slab of striated granite rises six feet out of the desert sands. Its bloodsoaked surface has been worn smooth by the crush of countless feet.

The **Thraxis Arena** is a medium-sized combat ring just outside the Shar Oasis (pg. 33).

Travelers gather there each night to bet on pit fights between all comers, from drunk amateurs to famous gladiators.

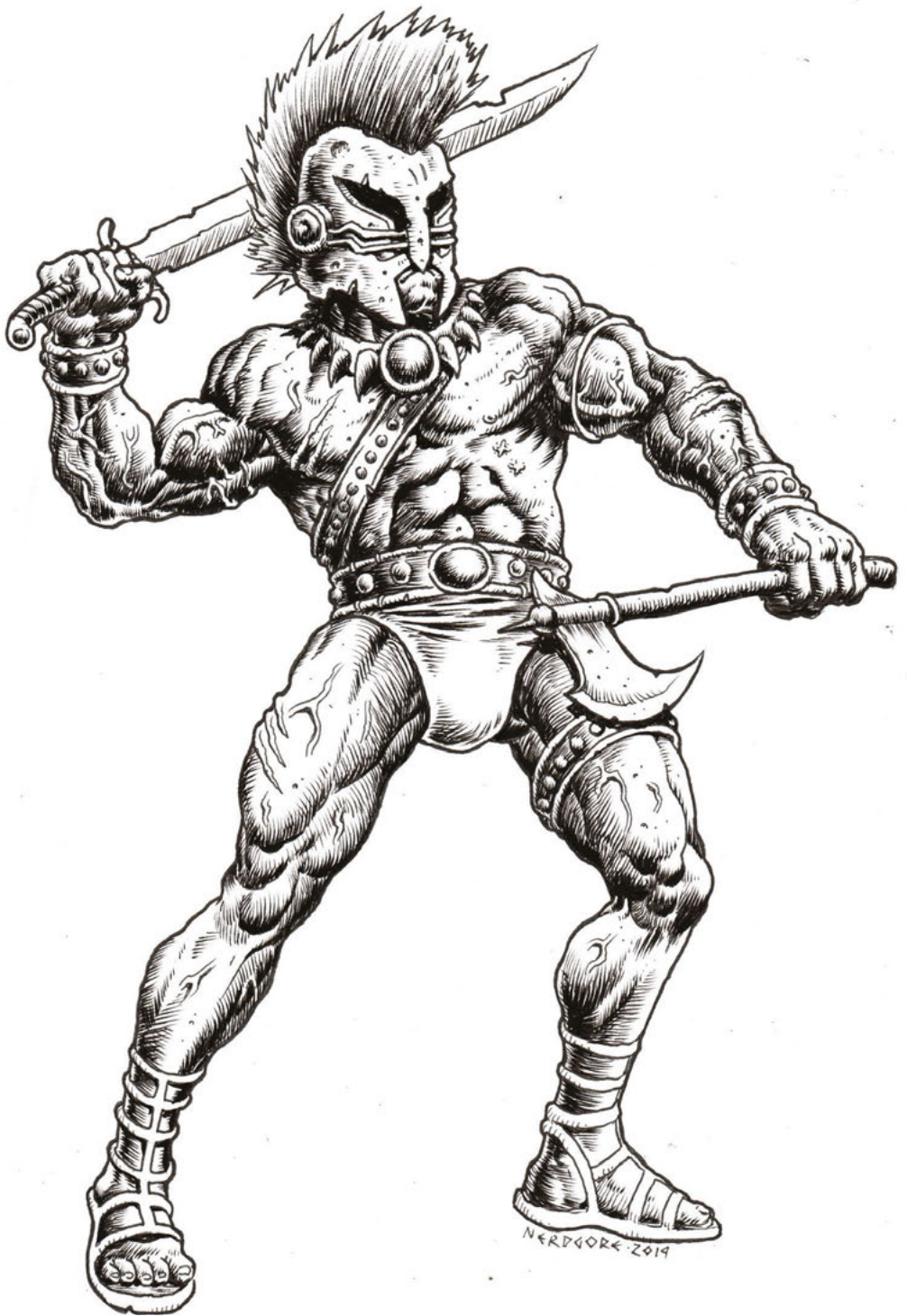
Some combatants are long-time residents of the oasis who earn their coin by fighting, while others roll in with the sunset and leave again at dawn.

**Bouts** take place at night with the arena lit by a haphazard ring of torches plunged into the sand. Spectators watch from the edge of darkness, filling the cool night with roars and cheers.

The crowd's **bloodthirst** sets the tone for the evening; in this lawless part of the desert, mercy is sometimes in short supply.

## TONIGHT'S CROWD

| d8 | Description                                                                                                        |
|----|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1  | <b>Ruthless.</b> A band of battle-scarred raiders howls for death                                                  |
| 2  | <b>Contemptuous.</b> Jeers aimed at the loser could erupt into calls for blood                                     |
| 3  | <b>Bored.</b> The crowd shouts for ever-greater thrills; they anger at monotony                                    |
| 4  | <b>Volatile.</b> Brawls and accusations of cheating break out between high stakes gamblers                         |
| 5  | <b>Horrificed.</b> Gasps ring out; religious pilgrims demand an end to this                                        |
| 6  | <b>Enthusiastic.</b> Caravaners and mercenaries might throw tokens to their favorite fighters                      |
| 7  | <b>Jovial.</b> High spirits abound; losing fighters are consoled with drink                                        |
| 8  | <b>Awed.</b> The attendees watch raptly; 10% chance one is a djinni in disguise who rewards an exceptional warrior |



# Enduring Wounds

If a PC survives going to 0 HP after a severe injury, they might suffer an enduring wound.

That character must pass a DC 12 CON check or roll on the below table for an immediate effect.

## ENDURING WOUNDS

### d20 Details

- |    |                                                                                                |
|----|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1  | <b>Heart Attack.</b> Pass a DC 15 CON check or perish instantly                                |
| 2  | <b>Lop.</b> You lose a limb. 1d4: <b>1.</b> Leg, <b>2.</b> Arm, <b>3.</b> Foot, <b>4.</b> Hand |
| 3  | <b>Blinded.</b> You lose an eye (DISADV on sight-based checks)                                 |
| 4  | <b>Torn Muscle.</b> You permanently lose 1 point of STR                                        |
| 5  | <b>Severed Tendon.</b> You permanently lose 1 point of DEX                                     |
| 6  | <b>Ruptured Spleen.</b> You permanently lose 1 point of CON                                    |
| 7  | <b>Concussion.</b> You permanently lose 1 point of INT                                         |
| 8  | <b> ringing Ears.</b> You permanently lose 1 point of WIS                                      |
| 9  | <b>Disfigured.</b> You permanently lose 1 point of CHA                                         |
| 10 | <b>Lingering Wound.</b> You permanently lose 1 HP                                              |
| 11 | <b>Shattered.</b> One piece of gear you wield is destroyed                                     |
| 12 | <b>Stubborn Bleed.</b> Lose 1d4 HP per round, lasts 1d4 rounds                                 |
| 13 | <b>Bell Rung.</b> You're utterly disoriented for 1d4 rounds                                    |
| 14 | <b>Sand Everywhere.</b> You're blinded for 1d4 rounds                                          |
| 15 | <b>Staggered.</b> DC 12 CON or lose your action, lasts 1d4 rounds                              |
| 16 | <b>Groggy.</b> You lose your next action                                                       |
| 17 | <b>Unnerved.</b> You have DISADV on all actions for 1d4 rounds                                 |
| 18 | <b>Dizzy.</b> You can only move a close distance for 1d4 rounds                                |
| 19 | <b>Scarred.</b> You're left with a brutal scar and a harrowing tale                            |
| 20 | <b>Miracle.</b> You have ADV on your next attack or check                                      |

# Poisons

Tinctures, powders, oils, and gases. Poisons come in all varieties and virilities, distilled from countless flowers, creatures, and fungi. They are almost always difficult to procure and illegal to possess.

Poison users must pass a DC 12 DEX check while employing them or poison themselves by mistake (trained users only poison themselves on a natural 1). Only living creatures of LV 10 or less are affected by poisons.

## POISONS

| d8 | Name            | Rarity   | Use          | Effects                                        |
|----|-----------------|----------|--------------|------------------------------------------------|
| 1  | Aminiita root   | Common   | Eat          | DC 12 CON or 3d6 damage                        |
| 2  | Bluewort paste  | Common   | Injure       | DC 12 CON or paralyzed 1d4 rds                 |
| 3  | Drowsy dust     | Uncommon | Touch (eyes) | DC 12 CON or deep sleep for 1d4 hours          |
| 4  | Ether of Idos   | Uncommon | Inhale       | DC 12 CON or vivid, waking nightmares 1d4 rds  |
| 5  | Kingslayer oil  | Uncommon | Eat          | DC 18 CON or delayed onset (1 hour) go to 0 HP |
| 6  | Nuzule oil      | Rare     | Injure       | DC 15 CON or unconscious 3 rds                 |
| 7  | Truth-speak oil | Rare     | Touch        | DC 18 CON or gibber truths 1 hr                |
| 8  | Vapor of Leng   | Rare     | Inhale       | DC 15 CON or INT stat becomes 3 for 1d4 hours  |

# Mounts

Mounts include beasts of burden and creatures with riders.

All humanoids can ride common and uncommon mounts. Rare mounts, like scrag, require special training to ride. See pg. 39 for new monsters.

## GEAR SLOTS

Mounts have a number of gear slots equal to 5x their STR bonus. A **rider** and the rider's carried gear (such as a backpack and worn items) occupy 10 slots.

## MOVEMENT

When riding a mount, you use its speed instead of your own.

**Push.** While traveling, a rider can push a mount to move a number of additional 6-mile hexes each day equal to its CON bonus.

A pushed mount must pass a DC 12 CON check or be unable to travel the next day. The DC increases by one step for each consecutive day of pushing.

## COMBAT

Most mounts bearing a rider can't attack in combat. However, a mount of LV 7+ may make one attack on its rider's turn.

Getting on or off a mount uses up the rider's movement.

A mount unaccustomed to fighting might **spook** during combat. The first time it or its rider is wounded, it must make a **morale** check.

## FOOD AND WATER

Warm-blooded mounts must consume **rations** equal to their base level each day (do not include bonus levels). Camels and cold-blooded mounts must only do this once per week.

Mounts can go three days beyond their limit without water and three weeks beyond their limit without food. After that, they take 1d8 damage per day that can't be healed until given a full feeding of food or water.

## MOUNTS

| Name          | Cost   | Spooks? | Rarity   | Properties     |
|---------------|--------|---------|----------|----------------|
| Camel         | 50 gp  | Yes     | Common   | -              |
| Camel, silver | 200 gp | No      | Rare     | -              |
| Donkey        | 40 gp  | Yes     | Common   | -              |
| Elephant      | 400 gp | No      | Rare     | -              |
| Horse         | 50 gp  | Yes     | Common   | ADV on morale  |
| Horse, war    | 100 gp | No      | Uncommon | Can wear armor |
| Scrag         | 150 gp | Yes     | Uncommon | -              |
| Scrag, war    | 250 gp | No      | Rare     | Can wear armor |

## MOUNT PERSONALITY

| 2d6 + CHA mod | Demeanor | Behaviors                       |
|---------------|----------|---------------------------------|
| 0-4           | Horrid   | Rebellious, stubborn, malicious |
| 5-7           | Ornery   | Only likes owner, sassy, rude   |
| 8-9           | Reliable | Steadfast, obedient, protective |
| 10+           | Lovely   | Loyal, sweet, affectionate      |

## MOUNT GEAR

| Name             | Cost   | Properties                                                               |
|------------------|--------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Armor, leather   | 30 gp  | AC 11 + DEX mod                                                          |
| Armor, chainmail | 80 gp  | AC 13 + DEX mod; DISADV swim and stealth; 2 slots                        |
| Armor, plate     | 150 gp | AC 15; no swim or stealth; 3 slots                                       |
| Armor, mithral   | x5     | Metal only; -1 slot; normal stealth/swim                                 |
| Saddle           | 30 gp  | Rider ADV on checks to stay mounted; 1 free for mount to carry           |
| Wagon            | 120 gp | No rider on mount; move at half speed; +15 gear slots; limit 1 per mount |



# The Djurum

---



**“Better to spill blood than water.”**  
-A desert rider saying

# Travel In The Sands

Roll once each day for wind and temperature conditions.

Travel during the day is **unsafe** (check for random encounters every 3 hours).

Travel at night is **risky** (check for encounters every 2 hours), and visibility is reduced to near.

## TEMPERATURE

**Hot.** If PCs travel in hot or hotter weather, they must consume an extra ration that day. Pushed mounts (see Movement, pg. 28), must also consume an extra ration.

**Inferno.** Traveling creatures take 1d6 damage each hour.

## WIND

**Driving.** Travel speed is halved. Navigation checks are one step harder than normal.

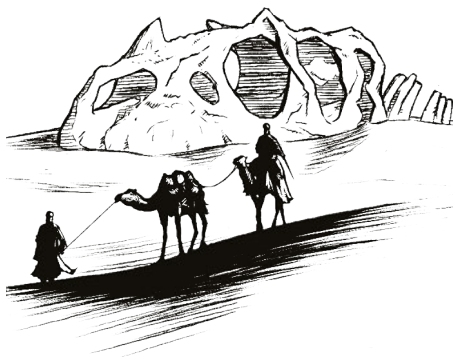
**Sandstorm.** Lasts 1d4 days (don't reroll for wind until it completes). Travel is impossible. No visibility.

### TEMPERATURE

| 2d6   | Day      | Night    |
|-------|----------|----------|
| 2     | Inferno  | Very hot |
| 3-7   | Very hot | Hot      |
| 8-9   | Hot      | Warm     |
| 10-11 | Warm     | Cool     |
| 12    | Cool     | Chilly   |

### WIND

| 2d6   | Day       | Night     |
|-------|-----------|-----------|
| 2     | Sandstorm | Sandstorm |
| 3-5   | Driving   | Gusty     |
| 6-9   | Gusty     | Breeze    |
| 10-11 | Breeze    | None      |
| 12    | None      | None      |



# The Djurum Hex Key

## 102. SIRUUL CAMP

The **Siruul**, a nomadic tribe of desert elves, maintains a secret camp here to rear and train their prized silver camels. 2d20 silky, pale-haired calves and their mothers range the flat scrubland under 40 elves' vigilant eyes. Anything that threatens the camels is met with swift, unforgiving violence. The rest of the 120 wandering elves, led by **Nuariel Siruul**, return here regularly with supplies.

## 106. FORTRESS RUINS

The shell of a once-mighty sandstone fortress lists in the dunes like a sunken ship. Blast marks mar its walls, and shards of blue-tinged glass pepper the sand around it. Twenty **ghosts** of its former guards materialize inside its broken halls each full moon, whispering curses upon a beast called **The Scourge** (1401). Only The Scourge's skull will bring them rest; they gift its bearer the *Scimitar of the Ash Moon* (**Shadowdark Core**).

## 109. WORM TRENCH

3d6 **purple worms** flock to these spawning grounds once every month. Four mothers remain to protect the webby nests filled with hatchling eggs (3d12) inside the 30' deep, 100' long trench. Scattered within the webs are a giant ruby (400 gp), a ragged *Flying Carpet*, and a +2 *razor chain* called Skinlasher whose wielder is immune to poison. The **Ras-Godai** (1203) view Skinlasher as a holy relic and would trade nearly anything for its return.

## 304. SHAR OASIS

The most plentiful pond of fresh springwater in The Djurum is a fragrant, palm-ringed hub bustling with travelers, merchant caravans, mercenaries, and outlaws. Its 60 permanent residents look to steely-eyed **Rameer the Lion**, a 50-year old former gladiator, for unofficial leadership. The famed **Thraxia Arena** (pg. 24) draws rowdy crowds each night to bet, drink sweet palm wine, and fight.

## 310. SALTSTONE TOWER

A lonely, salt-encrusted tower of grey stone thrusts like a needle out of the empty mineral flats. A grizzled, sharp-toothed **archmage** called The Wolf of Yarin (N) inhabits its drafty halls, digging endless, meandering tunnels beneath it with his trained purple worm, **Tajora**. The Wolf claims to hunt for a fissure that leads to the burning heart of the earth itself; after 50 years, he has found many strange things, but not that.

## 407. THE BONES

The bleached bones and skull of a titanic, prehistoric beast lie in the sand. Travelers sometimes take shelter under its towering ribs, stretching colorful cloths across the gaps to block the sun. At night, the wind humming through its skull seems to form soft words. The bones mark the halfway point on the caravan route between the **Shar Oasis** (304) and the city-state of **Alkesh** (709). Travelers who dare to journey north of the bones risk being spotted by the **Hawk Bandits** (505) in the southwestern Gilzai Mountains.

## 502. THE PYRE

The Pyre is a round, elevated altar of crimson marble engraved with dancing flames and set with ten fist-sized rubies (250 gp each). Each solstice, the nomadic **Siruul** elves (102) pile it with magnificent jewelry, art, and food in symbolic rejection of material goods. At midnight, the **phoenix** (702) erupts from the Gilzai Mountains and swoops down over the valley, touching The Pyre with its tail and turning all upon it into charcoal. The Siruul tenaciously hunt anyone who tampers with The Pyre.

## 505. HAWK BANDITS

Forty bandits dwell in a network of caves high in the southern Gilzai ridges. Their leader, a principled and magnetic young man named **Kadim** (N thief), has trained a dozen hawks to keep watch over the stretch of desert between the **Shar Oasis** (304) and **Alkesh** (709). The hawks signal the bandits when travelers stray into their reach. 3:6 chance 2d20 bandits guide their horses down hidden mountain passes to intercept anyone in an adjacent sand hex.

## 511. HAMAD CAMP

A tribe of 200 human desert-dwellers called the Hamad live near a natural spring at the edge of the salt flats. There, they hunt and tame wild scrag lizards; they're the only folk in The Djurum who do so. They hate and fear the sorcerer in **Saltstone Tower** (310), believing he is the source of recent bad luck causing foul water, illness, and stillbirth (the real source is a disguised rakshasa living among them). The tribe's leaders, twin sisters **Murjana** and **Delila**, are at odds about whether to attack the sorcerer or offer him a tribute tax. Murjana's eldest son, **Omid**, went missing in the salt flats a few weeks ago; she's certain the wizard is to blame.

## 702. PHOENIX

A **phoenix** roosts in the highest peak of the western mountains. It makes a flight over the desert at midnight on each solstice. During this breathtaking display, its nest is unguarded for an hour; within it are 2,000 gp, a *Ring of Fireballs*, three phoenix eggs, and a *Genie Lamp*. A blaze of fiery death awaits a caught thief.

## 706. HOWLING CAVES

Wind blows over the craggy faces of the Howling Caves, filling the silent desert with thrumming, hypnotic tones. Legend holds that a mad prince's treasure lies buried inside the caves, along with him.

## 709. ALKESH

The gleam of Alkesh's white walls and brass-plated domes can be seen for leagues. Natural springs and clever aqueducts feed its magnificent hanging gardens and orange trees. Young **Shar Yasmila** (and her scheming court) rule this city-state of 70,000 souls. Anything can be bought and sold here, and any throat cut for a price. The City of Red Sands has seven **districts**: The Alabaster Citadel (castle), The Spires (temple), The Gardens (high), The Suq (market), Silver Street (artisan), The Forgotten Quarter (low), and The Old Quarter (slum).

**The Jewel of Borak.** A tavern in the twisting back alleys of The Forgotten Quarter. Melted candles flicker in alcoves, and adventurers fill the cool air with spiced smoke and wild rumors.

## 804. CANYON MAZE

Within The Echoes canyonlands, a network of narrow ravines and gulches forms a disorienting maze. A navigator must pass a DC 18 Intelligence check to find an exit to the hex. Nomads tell tales of a flesh-eating efreeti who stalks the maze, tearing travelers apart in nighttime attacks. In truth, the creature haunting the maze is a vengeful canyon ape named **Gori-Mannu** who a long-dead sorcerer cursed with dim intelligence and the lifespan of ten men. Gori-Mannu has a cumulative 1:6 chance each day of finding creatures lost in the maze. He waits until night to attack, green eyes flashing like a mountain lion in the darkness.

## 907. RING OF GLASS MEN

Eight statues of humans made of blue-white glass stand in a circle with their arms thrown up protectively. They are a long-lost adventuring party called the **The Flying Tigers**, turned to glass by an ill-worded wish to a djinn. The *restoration* spell returns them to flesh. They gift their saviors an *Alabaster Destrier* and a **golden key** (see The Doors, 1509).

## 1110. MAGANI OASIS

Bull frogs croak in the reeds of the Magani Oasis, a blue-green pool 20 feet across. A mean **hippopotamus** called The Boss attacks anyone who enters the water. At the bottom of the pond, a *+1 scimitar* named Sunscorch lies half-buried in the sand. Once per day, it can emit a flash of white-hot light that blinds all who see it for 1 round.

Despite the oasis's humble size, there are always 2d12 travelers coming or going from **Alkesh** (709). There's a 3:6 chance some of these travelers have just been robbed and beaten by **Wadim's Thieves** (1208) and are recuperating from injury. They offer a cut of their cargo if the characters help them recover it.



### 1203. THE RAS-GODAI

Behind a secret door deep within The Echoes, a hidden monastery lurks in a sheltered ravine. Its tiered roofs of black wood are bathed in the dim glow of red paper lanterns. Six **Ras-Godai** watch the ravine from spy holes; they each carry blowguns with three nuzule oil darts (see Poisons, pg. 27).

Inside the monastery, 80 Ras-Godai assassins train from childhood under the half-demon **Manazusa** and his circle of five loyal oni. Aspirants are tested for many years in brutal trials of pain and self-mastery. Survivors earn the right to eat a single petal of the legendary **black lotus** flower that grows within the belly of the complex. Ras-Godai who endure the lotus's wracking magic earn the right to leave the monastery, but they must return yearly with an offering (or when called upon).

Once a decade, the monastery travels for a night to another plane so the cyclical black lotus can bathe in the light of the blood moon from its origin world. On this night, it grants one *wish* when its petals open.

### 1205. MANTICORE NEST

A pride of six adult **manticores** and three kits dwell in a high mountain cave. Creatures who enter an adjacent hex have a 3:6 chance of being noticed during the day. 1d4 adults attack anything that look like a meal. In their nest, the bodies of runaway **Omid** (511), his bride Zaina (an Alkeshi dancer), and his loyal war scrag have found their final rest. Omid wears a silver ring — a cursed band that causes the wearer's WIS to drop 1d8 points, removable only by *restoration*. His shredded bag contains a dowry of 80 gp.

### 1208. WADIM'S THIEVES

An upstart group of 20 thugs. They're led by a thief named **Wadim the Crooked** who is on the run after betraying the Thieves' Guild in **Alkesh** (709). The thugs are unused to harsh desert life, and Wadim's lieutenant, **Gaspar**, is planning a mutiny. They have broken the banditry code of honor by robbing everyone, including lone travelers; 2d8 thugs assail anyone in an adjacent hex. Everyone wants them gone.

## 1401. THE SCOURGE

An ancient **desert dragon** (pg. 43) makes its lair in the most desolate crag of the Gilzai. An unknown calamity corrupted its soul, and now it is a wicked force of chaos and destruction. It wings out over the desert at unpredictable intervals, throwing down lightning bolts at creatures it passes. Caravan trains would rather see all the bandits in The Djurum charging at them than spot The Scourge on the horizon. At the bottom of its labyrinthine lair, *The Staff of Ord* juts from a hill of 3,000 gp.

## 1409. VALE OF THE MOON

A still, hushed valley of pale sand nestles between a narrow range of scarlet peaks called the Silent Mountains. Not even the wind disturbs this barren place. The moon is always brightly visible, even at midday. The valley has a warping effect on time; one day of travel within is actually a week on the outside. All **dunefiends** in The Djurum originate here, slipping into the world between the gaps in reality. A random encounter has a 3:6 chance of being with 2d12 dunefiends.

## 1506. BURIED PYRAMID

A crumbling triangle of cut granite reaches five feet above the sand; the rest of the 80-foot tall pyramid looms beneath the surface. During sandstorms, the entire pyramid emerges in a nimbus of lacerating grit, and a pair of heavy, snake-inscribed doors in its side become accessible. As soon as the sandstorm abates, the desert once again swallows the pyramid beneath tons of earth.

## 1509. THE DOORS

Where the **Vale of the Moon** (1409) meets the Silent Mountains, a pair of towering doors 60 feet high rests in the rock, framed by a row of cyclopean pillars. A keyhole sits in the portal at chest height, but the lock won't open by any means other than the golden key last held by a long-lost adventuring party called **The Flying Tigers** (907). Rumors claim a mighty citadel where sorcerers and djinn walked the streets lies beyond The Doors, but nobody in The Djurum has passed through the silent gateway in a thousand years.

# Monsters

---

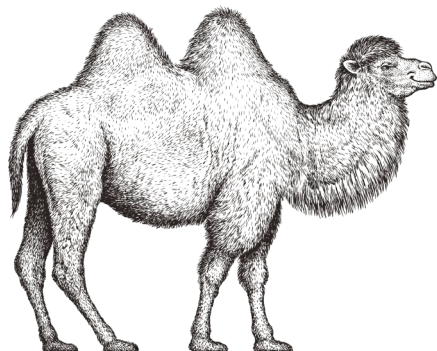


**"Keep an ear to the ground and an eye to the sky."**  
**-Common travelers' saying in The Djurum**

## CAMEL, SILVER

*Rare camels with soft, silvery hair and affable dispositions.*

**AC 10, HP 13, ATK 1** hoof +3 (1d6) or 1 spit (near) +0 (1d4), **MV** double near, **S** +3, **D** +0, **C** +4, **I** -2, **W** +1, **Ch** +0, **AL N**, **LV 2**



## CANYON APE

*Clawed apes with sandy, matted hair and reflective eyes. Carnivorous ambush hunters.*

**AC 13, HP 29, ATK 3** rend +6 (2d6), **MV** near (climb), **S** +4, **D** +3, **C** +2, **I** -1, **W** +1, **Ch** -1, **AL N**, **LV 6**

**Ambush.** Deals double damage against surprised foes.

**Stalk.** ADV on DEX checks while in mountains and canyons.

## DONKEY

*Stocky, long-eared cousins of horses that are capable haulers.*

**AC 10, HP 6, ATK 1** hoof +3 (1d4), **MV** near, **S** +3, **D** +0, **C** +2, **I** -2, **W** +1, **Ch** -2, **AL N**, **LV 1**

## DUNEFIEND

*Demons that appear as claylike elves with jagged mouths and no other facial features.*

**AC 14, HP 20, ATK 2** tear +4 (1d8) or 1 howl, **MV** near, **S** +3, **D** +4, **C** +2, **I** +0, **W** +1, **Ch** +0, **AL C**, **LV 4**

**Howl.** Resting creatures who hear in far DC 12 CHA or no benefit from rest (immune 1 day if pass).

## DUST DEVIL

*Whirling elementals of sand.*

**AC 16, HP 36, ATK 2** lacerate +5 (2d8), **MV** double near, **S** +4, **D** +4, **C** +0, **I** -2, **W** +0, **Ch** -2, **AL C**, **LV 8**

**Impervious.** Only damaged by magical sources.

**Fling.** In place of attacks, all within close DC 15 DEX or flung 1d100 feet in random direction.

## HERO

*High-ranked gladiators who have attained widespread fame.*

**AC** 16 (chainmail + shield), **HP** 25, **ATK** 3 bastard sword +5 (1d8) or 1 spear (close/near) +5 (1d6), **MV** near, **S** +3, **D** +1, **C** +3, **I** +0, **W** +1, **Ch** +1, **AL** N, **LV** 5

## HORSE, WAR

*Muscular destriers trained to carry warriors into combat.*

**AC** 11, **HP** 15, **ATK** 1 hooves +4 (1d6), **MV** double near, **S** +3, **D** +1, **C** +2, **I** -3, **W** +1, **Ch** -1, **AL** N, **LV** 3

## MIRAGE

*Sinister illusions made manifest by fever dreams and futile hope.*

**AC** 6, **HP** 32, **ATK** 1 leech, **MV** near, **S** -4, **D** -4, **C** -4, **I** +2, **W** +1, **Ch** +4, **AL** C, **LV** 8

**Delude.** Has the illusory look and feel of what its viewers expect or want it to be (creature or small location). DC 18 INT to notice it's an illusion.

**Leech.** One target in near, DC 18 CHA or 3d6 damage. Mirage creates plausible illusion to explain the injury.

## RAS-GODAI

*Black-garbed assassins in demon masks. They move swiftly in bursts of smoke.*

**AC** 13 (leather), **HP** 13, **ATK** 1 razor chain (near) +4 (1d6), **MV** near (teleport), **S** +1, **D** +2, **C** +0, **I** +0, **W** +1, **Ch** +0, **AL** C, **LV** 3

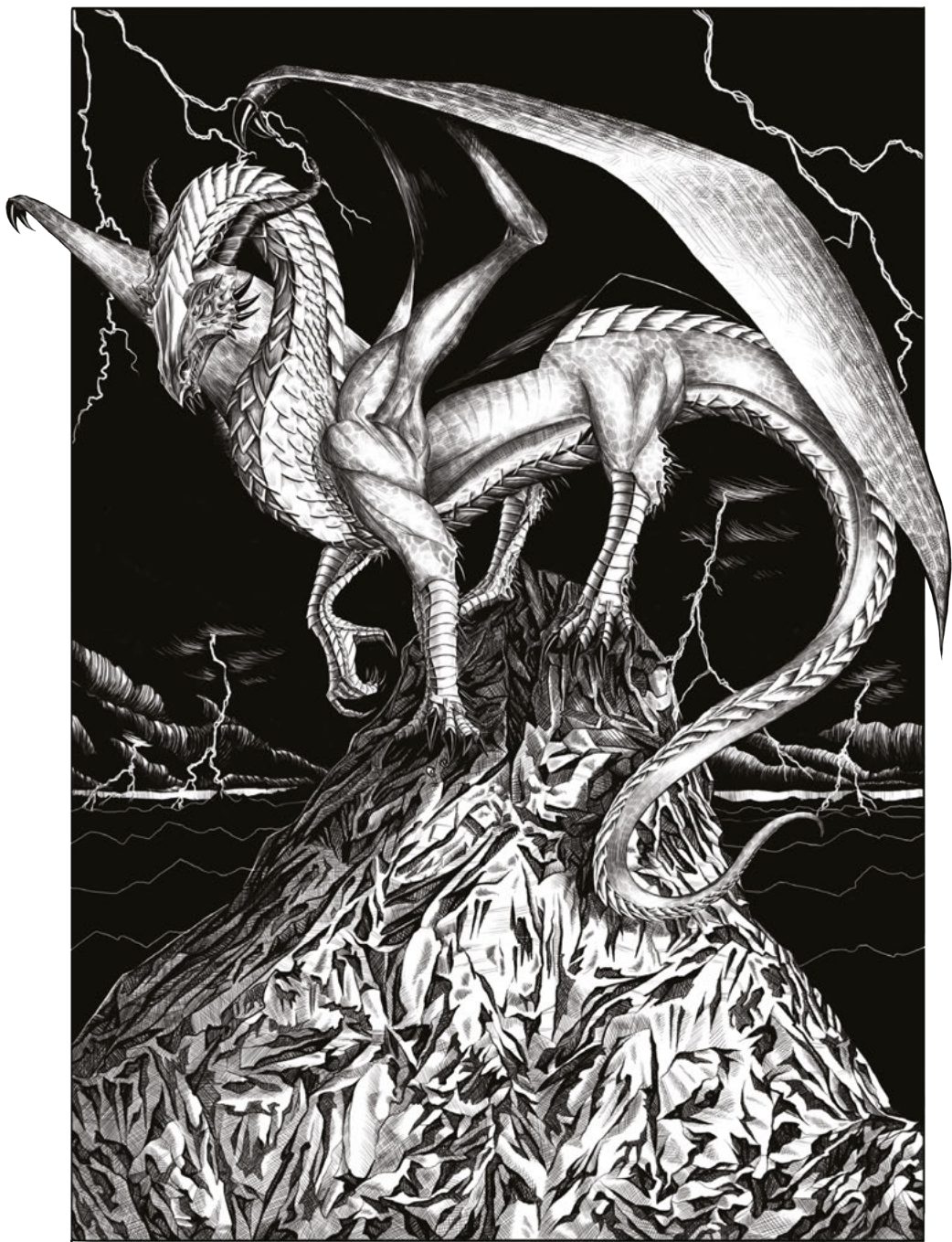
**Assassinate.** Deals double damage against surprised foes.



## ROOKIE

*Inexperienced pit fighters.*

**AC** 14 (leather + shield), **HP** 5, **ATK** 1 shortsword +1 (1d6) or 1 javelin (close/far) +1 (1d4), **MV** near, **S** +1, **D** +1, **C** +1, **I** +0, **W** +0, **Ch** +0, **AL** N, **LV** 1



*Stylized signature*



## SCRAG

*Tan monitor lizards as large as cows. They scamper low to the ground on wall-clinging feet.*

**AC** 12, **HP** 11, **ATK** 1 claw +2 (1d6),  
**MV** near (climb), **S** +2, **D** +2, **C** +2,  
**I** -2, **W** +1, **Ch** -3, **AL** N, **LV** 2



## SCRAG, WAR

*Oversized scrag lizards trained to be unflinching in combat.*

**AC** 12, **HP** 15, **ATK** 1 claw +3 (1d6),  
**MV** near (climb), **S** +3, **D** +2, **C** +2,  
**I** -2, **W** +1, **Ch** -3, **AL** N, **LV** 3



## SIRUUL

*Nomadic elves who glide as easily through the scorching desert as the winds.*

**AC** 14 (leather), **HP** 9, **ATK** 1  
scimitar +3 (1d6) or 1 longbow  
(far) +3 (1d8), **MV** double near  
(mount), **S** +0, **D** +3, **C** +0, **I** +1, **W**  
+1, **Ch** +1, **AL** N, **LV** 2

**Desert Born.** ADV on DEX checks while in the wild desert.

**Mount.** Loyal silver camel that refuses any other rider.



## THE SCOURGE

*The Scourge writhes and screams in constant pain. Its brass and lapis scales are choked with a sickly, green patina. Blue lightning snaps and coils in the air around it, and thunderclouds follow wherever it flies, but no rain falls from the tormented skies.*

**AC** 17, **HP** 84, **ATK** 3 rend +10 (2d10) or 1 lightning breath, **MV** double near (fly), **S** +6, **D** +3, **C** +3, **I** +4, **W** +4, **Ch** +5, **AL** C, **LV** 18

**Stormblood.** Electricity immune.

**Corruption.** Swallowed the *Shield of the Witch-King* to end an ancient war; the evil spirit inside tortures and corrupts the dragon.

**Lightning Breath.** A straight line (5' wide) extending double near from dragon. DC 15 DEX or 5d8 damage (DISADV on check if wearing metal armor).

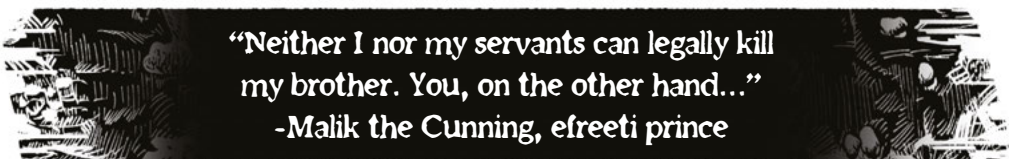
**Mirage.** 1/day, in place of attacks. Create 3 illusory duplicates that disappear when hit. Determine randomly what an attack hits.



# Fortress of the Burning Brothers

---

A 4th-6th-level adventure for Shadowdark RPG



**"Neither I nor my servants can legally kill  
my brother. You, on the other hand..."**

**-Malik the Cunning, efreeti prince**

# Overview

## ROOM KEY

---

The keyworded **descriptions** at the start of each location are safe to share with the players. The **bulleted details** beneath are for the GM.

## BACKGROUND

---

The efreeti lord **Pasha Jefar** has twin sons, **Malik** and **Gaspar**. Both are as cruel and conniving as their father. By the laws of the Sultan, Jefar must choose one of his firstborn sons to inherit his title. To determine their fate, Jefar has sent them to share the command of the **Iron Fortress**, a duergar mine on the Material plane. They know their unspoken task: Prove yourself worthy. The Sultan's law prohibits overt murder, so each brother seeks a deniable way to get rid of the other. Both crave to return to the City of Brass in triumph.

## FACTIONS

---

**Malik the Cunning.** Malik is thin as a whip and shrewd as a viper, wielding sorcery that even his tutors in the City of Brass feared to use. He's in charge of the rich mines and forgeworks beneath the Iron Fortress, as well as its **duergar** slaves — allies who are fanatically loyal to him due to his clever use of enslaving magic. He also has an opportunistic rakshasa ally, **Halim**, who spies on Gaspar.

**Gaspar the Fierce.** Gaspar towers over his brother, wielding his black-bladed scimitar with ferocity. He's in charge of the fortress itself and commands the militant **salamanders** who defend it. The salamanders have sworn an oath of allegiance to the efreet in exchange for elevated status in society; they're a cut above slaves. They're ruthlessly loyal to those who guarantee their position. **Rashik**, Gaspar's salamander spy, secretly lurks in the mines.

## THE IRON FORTRESS

---

The Iron Fortress was a duergar mining stronghold before falling to the efreet. It stands in a cathedral cavern deep inside the Howling Caves (pg. 35). Churning rivers of magma flow through the cave, filling the air with an orange glow and suffocating heat. The fortress is made of dark basalt with thick crenellations of blackened iron.

## THE MINES

---

A pitch-dark webwork of tunnels beneath the Iron Fortress. Duergar slaves hack relentlessly at the sharp rock, pulling out rich veins of iron and gold. The duergar use a vast furnace room to refine the ore, preparing it for its final destination in the City of Brass. The baking heat inside the cramped tunnels is stifling.



### RUMORS

- 1 "I got lost in the Howling Caves — wandered down there for days. At one point I came to a huge castle of black iron sitting on a river of fire! Everyone says I'm crazy, but I saw it. I swear."
- 2 "If you really listen, you can hear a *clang, clang, clang* coming from somewhere deep inside those cursed caves. I bet it's the wicked souls in hell hammering their own chains."
- 3 "They say a greedy prince hid all his treasure inside the caves. The howling sound is his dead spirit crying for more gold!"
- 4 "Those haunted mountains are rich with ore. Aye, and my uncle tried to set up a mining operation in them, too! Last fool thing he ever did. We haven't seen him in twenty years."
- 5 "We took shelter from a sandstorm in those caves, and I'm dead certain we were being watched the whole time. We heard footsteps and whispers. But nobody ever saw a thing!"
- 6 "My husband says the belly of the earth is full of flames. Says it's where all the creatures of fire and magic are born. Some strange old man wandering the salt flats told him that!"

# Iron Fortress (1-19)

## FEATURES

---

- **Light.** Magma fills the entire cavern with a dim, orange glow.
- **Walls.** 30' high, razor edges (ropes 2:6 tear). Smooth surface is impossible to climb with bare hands.
- **Towers.** 10' above walls (40' high), razor edges (ropes 2:6 tear).
  - ▶ **Iron ladders** (10', removable) connect walkways to towers.
- **Iron Crenels.** On walls and towers. DISADV to hit covered targets.
- **Interior Buildings.** Black basalt. Peaked roofs, 20' high at center.
- **Magma River.** 20' deep. Deals 5d10 damage/rd, death at 0 HP.

## ENCOUNTERS

---

- **Risky.** Check for a random encounter every **2 rounds** (1:6 chance).
- **Salamander Guards.** The salamanders look out into the cavern (DC 15 DEX to avoid notice from outside walls/DC 12 DEX inside).
  - ▶ **Guard Change.** Every two hours. Takes 1d4 rounds. During the rotation, it's easy to avoid notice (DC 9 DEX).
- **Order of Battle.** Each tower has a **brass gong** for raising the alarm. If raised, the 12 salamanders atop towers (Areas 2, 3, 8, 11, 12, 16, 17) provide longbow cover, and the 13 from Areas 5, 6, and 7 arm and muster in the courtyard (Area 4) in 2 rounds.
  - ▶ **Gaspar.** A third of the salamanders go to protect him (Area 8).
  - ▶ **Sweeps.** Salamanders atop towers remain in position. The rest sweep the fortress in groups of 3-5 for an hour. Intruders are preferably **captured alive** and taken before Gaspar.
  - ▶ **Afterwards.** Guard numbers double for 24 hours after an alarm is raised. All checks to avoid notice become DC 18.

## SALAMANDER GUARDS

---

Guard rotations mean the salamanders change locations every two hours. Roll on the **Salamander NPCs** list on pg. 63 when you need to determine who is currently nearby. Remove dead NPCs from the list.



### RANDOM ENCOUNTERS

#### d6 Details

---

- 1 1d4 **salamanders** take a **duergar** slave to prison (Area 10) who they caught sneaking around outside of the mines
  - 2 **Halim** (Malik's rakshasa spy) in illusory disguise as a salamander; he's fishing for gossip from another **salamander**
  - 3 A spooked **nightmare** that escaped from the stables (Area 18) crashes toward where the PCs are
  - 4 2d4 vicious **scorpions** burst from the shadows
  - 5 **Gaspar** (Area 8) angrily storms toward a nearby building with a retinue of 4 **salamanders**
  - 6 A **strangler** that crept into the fortress follows the PCs and tries to stealthily pick off the rear character
- 



### 1. GATE OF FIRE

---

A glowing river of **magma** flows beneath the teeth of an iron **portcullis** and into a shadowy courtyard. Two sturdy towers flank the river; burning figures move about on top of them.

- **Salamanders.** Two salamanders watch Area 1 from the towers in Areas 2 and 3. Their flamelike coloration creates the illusion of fire.
- **Magma.** Magma completely fills the 10' wide entrance, leaving no walkway on either side. It passes into the courtyard (Area 4).
- **Portcullis.** Sits just above the surface of the magma. The **winch** in Area 2 raises and lowers it.

## 2. WEST GATE TOWER

---

A **salamander** watches from the top of the fortified tower; a brass gong stands a few steps away from it.

- **Interior.** Grimy floors. A hefty **winch** protrudes from the east wall.
  - ▶ **Winch.** Raises or lowers the **iron portcullis** (Area 1) in 2 rounds.
  - ▶ **Paper Scrap.** In a dirty corner. Torn. Says, "...and I know they don't respect you, Malchiz. Come speak to me in the mines..."

## 3. EAST GATE TOWER

---

A **salamander** stands guard beside a hammered brass gong.

- **Interior.** Six weighty, dark **rocks** are strewn about the floor. An iron sculpture of a smirking **dwarf face** hangs from the door.
  - ▶ **Rocks.** Lifting one causes a stream of magma to gout from a small hole in the flagstone (DC 12 DEX or 3d8 damage).
  - ▶ **Dwarf Face.** Touching it while speaking in Dwarvish causes the matched faces (Area 8, 16) to animate and repeat the words.

## 4. COURTYARD

---

Looming buildings of black stone surround a courtyard split by a churning river of magma. A **bridge** arches over its fiery path.

- **Danger Level.** Deadly (a high-traffic area). Check for random encounters every round (1:6 chance).
- **Bridge.** A **duergar** named Rotid crouches in the shadows under the bridge. Anyone crossing has a 2:6 chance of hearing his ragged mouth-breathing.
  - ▶ **Rotid.** Asthmatic, jumpy, wild hair. Malik (Area 21) sent him to spy on the guard rotation schedule. If discovered, he turns invisible and flees toward the secret door in area Area 13.
- **Broken Flagstone.** Where Area 18 meets the south wall, a cracked flagstone lifts to reveal a *Potion of Fire Protection* (immunity to fire for 5 rounds) and a glass vial containing 2 *Beads of Force*.

## 5. MESS HALL

---

Six **salamanders** hiss and spit at each other around a broad iron table. They pause only to grab fleshy **fire slugs** off the table and jam them in their mouths.

- **Salamanders.** Arguing in sibilant Common about each other's failures on the job. Nobody is safe from lacerating critique.
  - ▶ 3:6 chance a brawl breaks out that lasts 1d4 rounds. During this time, DEX checks to sneak past them are easy (DC 9).
- **Fire Slugs.** 2d4 on the table, potato-sized, quivering lumps of orange flesh. They try to inch away and leave trails of burning oil. Can be thrown near, explode in flames on impact (1d6).

## 6. CAPTAIN'S QUARTERS

---

A hammock of woven iron threads hangs from the ceiling. A dented brass **chest** with a heavy latch sits beneath it.

- **Trap.** A faint arc of enchanted gold dust encircles the floor in front of the inside door. Any creature who breaks the ring summons a hostile **fire elemental (lesser)** for 2d4 rounds.
- **Captain Isshak.** 3:6 chance Isshak, the salamander captain, is sleeping in the hammock. If not, he's in Area 8. He has the **key** to the brass chest on an iron cord around his neck.
  - ▶ **Isshak.** Charcoal scales, sinewy, shrewd. Wields a black iron *+1 spear* called Screamer. It shrieks hideously when thrown.
- **Brass Chest.** Locked (DC 20 DEX pick, DC 18 STR break). Empty. A secret compartment in base hides an obsidian ring shaped like a cobra with ruby eyes (80 gp), 200 gp, and a *Potion of Healing*.

## 7. BARRACKS

---

Snoring, hissing salamanders sleep in rows of double bunk beds.

- **Salamanders.** Six sleep here in shifts. Loud noises wake them. Their weapons hang from hooks on each bunk.

## 8. CASTELLAN'S TOWER

---

Three **salamanders** keep watch from a tower that looms over all the others. Its iron crenels are shaped into a crown of cruel barbs.

- **Interior.** A high-backed, granite chair sits before a **desk** stacked with piles of clay tablets. Sparking braziers belch out blue-black **incense**. A sneering, iron **dwarf face** hangs from the west door.
  - ▶ **Gaspar** (efreeti, LV 12, +9 melee). **5:6 chance** he's at the desk white-knuckling through tedious work (if not, he's in Area 9).
    - ▷ Meticulous. Forcefully contained anger just below the surface. Plans to kill Malik using the broken **iron golem** in Area 13. Offers the PCs safety and one of his prized **nightmares** (Area 18) if they help, or, better yet, kill Malik themselves. Throws unruly PCs in the prison (Area 10).
    - ▷ Granting a mortal a *wish* (especially under duress) is an unbearable dishonor to an efreeti noble; he'd rather die.
  - ▶ **Isshak** (salamander captain, Area 6). **3:6 chance** he's here to talk to Gaspar about "the dwarf spies." If not, he's sleeping (Area 6).
  - ▶ **Incense.** Intoxicating to the unaccustomed. DC 12 CON or become clumsy and suggestible (DISADV on related checks).
  - ▶ **Dwarf Face.** Touching it while speaking in Dwarvish causes the matched faces (Area 3, 16) to animate and repeat the words.

## 9. GASPAR'S QUARTERS

---

Two **salamanders** stand at firm attention outside a towering, iron door. Its surface is carved with lines that weave to form knots.

- **Salamanders.** **Skizzik** (blood red, grim, calm) and **Burgaz** (saffron, muscled, brash), honor guards. Alert (DC 18 DEX to avoid notice).
- **Interior.** Plush bed, red and gold silk. Six obsidian plaques with five mithral **horseshoes** (one missing). Silk robes on hooks.
  - ▶ **Gaspar.** 1:6 chance he's here sleeping (if not, he's in Area 8).
  - ▶ **Horseshoes.** The nightmares' (Area 18) trophies. 100 gp each.

## 10. PRISON

---

A salamander stands guard before two blocks of barred cells that reek like animal cages. Dark **shapes** lie inside them. Muted **shrieks** come from behind the east door at irregular intervals.

- **Salamander. Fazed** (pale yellow, snide, boastful). Has a cell key.
- **Shapes.** Four miserable, bruised **duergar** lie in their own filth (use Duergar NPCs tables, pg. 64). Cell locks DC 20 DEX to pick.

## 11. NORTHEAST TOWER

---

A **salamander** patrols around the top of the tower, pausing every so often to glare out into the cavern. A dull brass gong hangs in a shadowy corner. Faint **screams** emanate from somewhere below.

- **Gong.** Inspection reveals it's cracked in two (can't be rung).
- **Interior.** A grey-skinned, shirtless **dwarf** with snowy hair and beard hangs from wall manacles. A hissing **salamander** pokes him with a red-hot trident, eliciting ragged yelps.
  - ▶ **Salamander. Usmik** (wine-red, cruel, impatient). Interrogating duergar ("Why were you skulking around up here?" "What's Malik planning?"). Has key to manacles and cells (Area 10).
  - ▶ **Duergar. Gungol** (young, filthy, defiant, magically enslaved by Malik). Answers all questions with, "Only Malik knows!"

## 12. REAR GATEHOUSE

---

Two **salamanders** watch from the tower, a brass gong between them. Magma flows beneath the spikes of a rusty **portcullis** set in the tower's center. A dim courtyard lurks beyond the gate.

- **Tower.** A roof **crank** raises or lowers the portcullis in 2 rounds. It's rusted shut (DC 15 STR each round to operate).
- **Portcullis.** Rusted iron **bars** (bends on DC 20 STR).
- **Magma.** Magma completely fills the 10' wide entrance, leaving no walkway on either side. It passes into the courtyard (Area 4).

## 13. DESECRATED TEMPLE

---

Dusty, brooding silence. A toppled iron **statue** lies amid the pieces of a shattered stone altar. Carvings of lines and knots fill the walls.

- **Statue (Broken Iron Golem).** 10-foot tall duergar god, Dorgrim; hollow eye sockets. Deactivated by efreet invaders long ago. Requires a magical pair of **ruby eyes** to power it (Malik, Area 21, has recently found them, but doesn't know what they do yet).
  - ▶ Gaspar has learned how the golem works from old records and now seeks the rubies; he wants to let it loose in the mines in a "horrific accident" to kill his brother. In **2d4 days**, his salamander spy (**Rashik**, Area 30) discovers the rubies' location.
- **Secret Door.** Rotating panel. Only the duergar know of it.

## 14. VAULT

---

A scarred iron door bears a **lock** inside the mouth of a snarling dwarf. Gruff voices and metallic clanging echo from the other side.

- **Lock.** DC 20 DEX to pick. Too fortified to be smashed open.
- **Interior. Dwarves** with wild, white hair stagger up a set of stairs with armloads of ingots they dump unceremoniously on the floor.
  - ▶ **Duergar.** Four from the Duergar NPCs table (pg. 64).
  - ▶ **Ingots.** 30 iron (10 gp each) and 20 gold (20 gp each).
- **Secret Door.** Rotating panel. Only the duergar know of it.

## 15. EXTRAPLANAR PORTAL

---

A billowing curtain of **fire** rages along the south wall. Oven-like heat.

- **Duergar.** 3:6 chance a **duergar** is here tossing 5 gold ingots (20 gp each) into the flames (use Duergar NPCs table, pg. 64).
- **Fire.** Passing through the fire deals 4d6 damage. It leads to a swooping ivory and brass balcony in the inferno-hot City of Brass. Four **efreet** guards try to cast all but their own back through.
  - ▶ Malik and Gaspar are currently forbidden from passing through.

## 16. WEST TOWER

---

Two **salamanders** peer out into the cave from behind the thick, iron crenels; a shiny brass gong sits between them.

- **Interior.** Numerous scuffs in the ash and grime on floor. An iron sculpture of an evilly grinning **dwarf face** hangs from the door.
  - ▶ **Dwarf Face.** Touching it while speaking in Dwarvish causes the matched faces (Area 3, 8) to animate and repeat the words.
  - ▶ **Hidden Door.** Dwarf-sized bootprints lead to a hidden **trapdoor** in the floor (to Area 24). The salamanders are unaware of it.

## 17. SOUTHWEST TOWER

---

Two **salamanders** patrol around the broad tower's parapets. A gong glints in the magma-light behind them.

- **Interior.** Faint snorting and clip-clopping audible through door.
  - ▶ **Salamander.** 3:6 chance a salamander is crouching in here gorging on 2d4 fire slugs pilfered from the mess hall (Area 5).

## 18. STABLES

---

Three jet-black **horses** with flaming manes trot around spacious, iron stalls. A runty **salamander** brushes jasmine oil into their coats.

- **Horses.** Thoroughbred racing **nightmares**. Zenda, Burning Moon, Red Sultan. Each worth 500 gp. Vicious; only allow chaotic riders.
- **Salamander.** Xaviss. Unarmed, shrimpy, self-important. Takes care of the nightmares. Mithral horseshoe (100 gp) hidden among his tools that he filched from Gaspar's quarters (Area 9).

## 19. HIDDEN MINE ENTRANCE

---

A squat stalagmite has a cleft at its point, as if split by an axe.

- **Concealed Stairs.** The stalagmite echoes if tapped. A hidden door in its north side reveals narrow stairs leading down to the mines.
  - ▶ Only the duergar know of this entrance.

# Mines (20-35)

## FEATURES

---

- **Light.** Dim light in rooms with magma. Otherwise, total darkness.
- **Tunnels.** Flinty, black granite. 10' high unless noted. The constant clangor of mining and forging makes sneaking easy (DEX DC 9).
- **Magma.** 20' deep. Deals 5d10 damage/rd, death at 0 HP.

## ENCOUNTERS

---

- **Risky.** Check for a random encounter every **2 rounds** (1:6 chance).
- **Duergar.** They bellow for help if under attack; all duergar in adjacent rooms arrive in 1d4 rounds. They try to **capture** invaders and bring them before Malik rather than kill them.
- **Order of Battle.** The duergar don't have an organized defense; they rely on yelling to nearby allies for help. If their morale breaks, they flee toward Malik in Area 21, collecting allies along the way.
  - ▶ **Malik.** If alerted, he barricades in Area 22 with any duergar at hand and casts defensive spells on himself. If no threat materializes after an hour, he sends the duergar back to work.
  - ▶ **Afterwards.** Malik and duergar are more alert for 24 hours after an incident (DC 15 DEX to escape their notice).

## DUERGAR SLAVES

---

Most duergar are under the effects of *enslave* spells Malik regularly refreshes. Repeated brainwashings have given them all a shared, cultish devotion to Malik, even without the magic (DC 15 CHA for an un-enslaved duergar to overcome fanaticism, if given evidence).

When the PCs encounter **unnamed** duergar, determine who they are with the Duergar NPCs list on pg. 64. Remove dead duergar.



## RANDOM ENCOUNTERS

### d6 Details

- 
- 1 A concussive blast of hot air blows out any torches/lanterns
  - 2 1d4 **hell hounds** broken loose from the kennels (Area 28) race up the halls, looking to cause mayhem
  - 3 1d6 grouchy **duergar** hurrying to the forge hall (Area 20) to start their shift; fearful of being late
  - 4 **Rashik** (Area 30), Gaspar's salamander spy, slinks through the halls and eavesdrops
  - 5 2d4 exhausted **duergar** headed to rest (Area 27) after their work shift; DISADV for them to notice hidden creatures
  - 6 A roving **bulette** breaks through the wall, goes on a rampage (1d4 rounds), and then retreats into its collapsing tunnel
- 



## 20. FORGE HALL

**Duergar** toil at massive forges set before a surging lake of magma. Their dolorous chanting keeps a tempo for their ringing hammer strikes. The air shimmers with intense **heat**.

- **Heat.** Unaccustomed creatures DC 12 CON upon entering or DISADV on attacks and checks until leaving.
- **Duergar.** Eight sweating duergar smelt iron and gold ingots.
  - ▶ Forgemaster **Torgrim** (burly, dour, singed hair) watches with his arms crossed. Bellows instructions. Pretends to be loyal to Malik, but hates him. He's the only duergar not brainwashed.
- **Forges.** Four. Iron grates that belch flames. Opening a grate unleashes a gout of fire (DC 12 DEX to all in close or 2d6 damage).
  - ▶ **Ingots.** 2 gold (20 gp each) and 4 iron (10 gp each) in each forge.

## 21. MALIK'S QUARTERS

---

A thick, iron lock seals a stone **door** streaked with black forge ash.

- **Lock.** DC 20 DEX to pick, DC 20 STR to force. Malik has the **key**.
- **Interior.** Two growling, black-haired **wolves** flank the entrance, magma dripping from their jaws. A rumpled bed of scarlet silk sits in the corner, and piles of creased robes litter the floor.
  - ▶ **Hell Hounds.** Eyesore and Scab-Biter. Snorting, frothing brutes. DC 12 WIS for them to hear noise outside (they go wild).
    - ▷ **Gold-Spiked Collars.** One on each hound. 80 gp each.
  - ▶ **Malik** (efreeti). 3:6 chance he's here resting (otherwise, Area 22).
    - ▷ Disheveled, charming, intense. Bruised face. Practices night and day to summon and control a **greater earth elemental** long enough to "accidentally" unleash it near his brother (it's not going well). Offers the PCs safety and a trained **hell hound** each (from Area 28, hounds worth 100 gp each) if they'll help him or kill Gaspar. Locks unruly PCs in Area 29.
    - ▷ **Spellcasting.** 1 spell in place of attacks, **+6. DC 11:** *cloak of flame* (self, 5 rounds, AC 17), *enslave* (1 humanoid target, close, fervently loyal 1d6 days). **DC 13:** *whitefire* (as *fireball*, ignores fire immunity). **DC 15:** *convoke greater elemental* (as *convoke entity*, elementals of LV 9 only).

## 22. SECRET SUMMONING LAIR

---

An intricate **circle** drawn in red paint covers the floor. Shattered stone furniture and plate-sized holes pepper the room. The only intact object is a stone **desk** scattered with overturned books.

- **Malik.** 3:6 chance he's here tinkering with the summoning circle (otherwise, Area 21). He keeps losing control of earth elementals.
- **Summoning Circle.** +1 on spellcasting checks to summon beings.
- **Twin Rubies.** On desk under an open book. Eye-shaped, 200 gp each. They power the **iron golem** in Area 13 (Malik isn't aware).

## 23. MINING TUNNELS

---

Twisting **tunnels** reach into the dark rock. Metallic clanging and baritone chanting reverberate loudly, drowning out other sounds.

- **Duergar.** Two chip at the stone in the western tunnels. Noise from Area 20 hides any sounds they make.
  - **Ore.** Each carries a bucket with 20 gp of gold ore nuggets.

## 24. DEFACED STATUES

---

Three alcoves each hold a **statue** of a stocky figure. A pile of oddly shaped **rubble** lies against the west wall. **Stairs** rise to the ceiling.

- **Statues.** Grim duergar with limbs hewn off and hollow eye sockets. Inspection reveals pry marks around their eyes.
- **Rubble.** Broken statue limbs. An eye-shaped **emerald** (120 gp) is buried in the pile. If placed in a statue, the statue whispers in Dwarvish in a dying voice: "Find Thorgol the Anvil..."
- **Stairs.** Rise to a trapdoor to Area 16 (hidden from other side).

## 25. NAGA CAVE

---

A billowing **curtain** of black silk hangs over a wide cave entrance.

- **Interior.** An enormous, blood-red **cobra** coils itself on a pile of sumptuous cushions. A **duergar** and **salamander** hang from the ceiling on bronze chains (food offerings from Malik and Gaspar).
  - **Cobra.** Vilaxis Morgotha, **naga** (sneering, droll, flashing eyes and tongue). A servant of Pasha Jefar, Gaspar and Malik's father. Neutral observer to make sure the brothers kill each other fairly.
    - Finds PCs amusing. Asks whether they think Malik or Gaspar is superior. Happily shares routine information about either. Savagely devours the duergar and salamander while talking.
  - **Duergar.** Cut throat. Very dead.
  - **Salamander.** Grievous stab wound, but alive. Whimpers and kicks slightly. Use Salamander NPCs (pg. 63), if needed.

## 26. IRON TREES

---

A gnarled, black **tree** grows in each alcove. Glistening **fruits** hang from their twisted branches. Dark, powdery stones cover the floor.

- **Iron Trees.** Metallic bark. Their magical fruits ripen and wither each day, dropping off and turning into chunks of coal.
  - ▶ **Iron Plums.** Quench all thirst, taste of bitter anise. Induce drowsiness (DC 12 CON or sleep for 1 hour).
  - ▶ **Iron Pears.** Sour. Fully nourishing, but never relieves hunger.
  - ▶ **Iron Oranges.** Cure injury (2d8 HP, once/day). Taste of copper.

## 27. DUERGAR CAMP

---

A vast, natural cavern cut through with a glowing river of magma. Grey **dwarves** lie against the walls wrapped in their cloaks, snoring. An arched **bridge** crosses over the magma river.

- **Duergar.** Eight sleep here (loud noises wake them). Some still clutch half-eaten iron tree fruits (Area 26) in their hands.
  - ▶ **Gear.** Dwarvenkind sleep on their shields and cradle their weapons. DC 12 DEX to remove either without waking them.

## 28. HELL HOUND KENNELS

---

Six wolf-sized **mongrels** lope around the room, snarling and snapping at each other. A grey **dwarf** walks among them and growls commands, cracking a length of chain at any who defy him.

- **Duergar.** Kennelmaster **Morgid** (white mohawk, confident, brash). Wields a razor chain (pg. 17) in place of shield and war pick. The hell hounds fear and obey him.
- **Hell Hounds.** Six beasts trained as Malik's guards and war dogs. DC 12 WIS for them to hear noises, even when asleep.
  - ▶ **Silver-Spiked Collars.** One on each hound. 20 gp each.
- **North Door.** Locked from the outside. DC 20 DEX to pick, 20 STR to force. The key is long lost.

## 29. EMPTY CELL

---

An expansive prison cell large enough to hold an elephant. Faint **scratches** cover the stone walls.

- **Lock.** DC 20 DEX to pick. Too heavy to break open.
- **Scratches.** Countless tally marks and phrases carved in Dwarvish ("Efreet murderers," "Dorgrim rot their souls," "Thorgol hidden up the river," "Replace the statue's ruby eyes").

## 30. SILENT GALLERY

---

Dusty, quiet cavern with burbling river of magma cutting off passage to the north. Flickering, orange light. Deep shadows.

- **Rashik.** Salamander spy for Gaspar (coal-black scales, sinister, observant). Sleeps in the shadowy corners between furtive outings. Dives into the magma river to hide if he hears intruders.
  - ▶ In 2d4 days, he discovers Malik (Area 21) unknowingly has the **rubies** that power the broken **iron golem** in Area 13.
- **South Door.** Locked from the inside. DC 20 DEX to pick, 20 STR to force. The key is long lost.

## 31. MINE JUNCTION

---

Vast cavern echoing with distant hammer strikes and chanting. Intricate **carvings** on the walls. Branching passages twist off in every direction.

- **Danger Level.** Deadly (a high-traffic area). Check for random encounters every round (1:6 chance).
- **Noise.** Noise from Area 20 makes sneaking quietly easy (DC 9).
- **Carvings.** Bas-relief of great skill. Depicts dozens of grim duergar mining the stone and building the Iron Fortress. A duergar in a spiked crown lifts a black warhammer (*Thorgol the Anvil*).
- **Steep Slope.** Creatures running down tunnel toward Area 30 DC 12 DEX or fall. Roll into magma river if fail by 5+ points.

## 32. MINING TUNNELS

---

A lone **duergar** probes at a shallow niche in the wall with a pickaxe.

- **Duergar.** Working on expanding a new southern tunnel.
  - **Ore.** Carries a bucket with worthless iron chips and, unknown to him, a geode holding a small **sapphire** (100 gp).

## 33. MINING TUNNELS

---

Three grumbling **duergar** hack at the flinty rock with pickaxes.

- **Duergar.** DISADV on checks to notice sneaking creatures.
  - **Ore.** Each carries a bucket with worthless iron chips.
- **Weak Wall.** The southernmost tunnel has a weak wall (visible to any dwarf). An explosive force opens it into Area 35.

## 34. MINING TUNNELS

---

Ear-splitting clanging and deep chanting echoes from the west.

- **Duergar.** Works in the southernmost tunnel. Noise from Area 20 masks any sounds he makes.
  - **Ore.** Bucket with 20 gp of gold nuggets and a lost **scorpion**.

## 35. HIDDEN CAVE

---

A dull black **rowboat** lies on its side against the cave wall. A boiling **magma** river drains into a dark, narrow pit.

- **Rowboat.** Magical iron (500 pounds) carved with intricate knots. Floats on magma. Water rusts it instantly. Two oars, four riders.
  - **Warhammer.** *Thorgol the Anvil* lies inside the rowboat. Heavy, black iron with triangular knots on each face. +2 *warhammer* that can instantly fuse together two metal objects it strikes at the same time, if its wielder chooses.
    - Duergar immediately **rally** around anyone wielding *Thorgol*.
- **Magma.** Drains deep into the fathoms of the Shadowdark.

# Salamander NPCs

1. **Aliz.** Glittering orange, zealous, militant. Turns on cowardly allies.
2. **Baltazir.** Glorious frills of blue-white. Proud, regal. Rather competent.
3. **Boaba.** Deep purple scales. Ambitious, alert (DC 15 to avoid his notice).
4. **Chalim.** Purple-black, grinning, sly. Accepts bribes. Has an escape plan.
5. **Chazzik.** Scarlet, shifty, resentful. Mutters insults ("ice sculpture," "slug guzzler"). 3:6 chance he "slips" and shoves a comrade over the crenels.
6. **Dagask.** Burgundy red, long frills. Secret scorpion pet, Carcal; coats arrows in its poison. Has three nuzule oil arrows (see Poisons, pg. 27).
7. **Daoud.** Red with orange patches. Swaggers. Expert with spear (ADV).
8. **Girassk.** Crimson, wobbly. Sneaks Murgazi wine (DC 9 to avoid his notice).
9. **Gorgiz.** Albino. Can barely stand the heat. Immune to cold, not fire.
10. **Gorvis.** Mustard yellow, eye patch, grim. Can actually see from both eyes.
11. **Halim** (rakshasa). Orange with black lines, sharp gaze. Malik's spy in illusory disguise. Subtly helps PCs, tries to turn them against Gaspar.
12. **Harazad.** Maroon scales. Vicious. Can't resist chance to harass duergar.
13. **Kazim.** Golden yellow, very tall. Sings loudly. Terrible archer (DISADV).
14. **Lamir.** Amber yellow, chirpy, naive. Loves strange food. Easy to deceive.
15. **Malchiz.** Blue-black scales, sullen. Younger brother of Isshak (Area 6). Constantly hazed by peers. Considering secret alliance with Malik (Area 21).
16. **Mordiz.** Canary yellow. Squeamish; 3:6 faints at first sight of blood.
17. **Nurgaz.** Mottled red. Whiny, lazy. If alone, 3:6 of sleeping standing up.
18. **Nurim.** Burnt orange, blue tongue. Gossipy, mirthful. Everyone likes him.
19. **Sinzik.** Spooky, red eyes. Stares. Sees *everything* (DC 18 to avoid notice).
20. **Valkis.** Orange, shrill, eager to ring the gong. 3:6 his first ring is ignored.
21. **Vishak.** Plum red, dangerously quiet. Deft interrogator. Hard to deceive.
22. **Zangis.** Ragged, red frills. Dumpy, sad. Misses the City of Brass.

# Duergar NPCs

1. **Bolgrim.** Only three teeth. Jolly, for a duergar. Sinister cackle.
2. **Borg.** Young, muscled, quiet. Father was a blacksmith. He hates smithing.
3. **Dagrin.** Frizzy hair. Spooky, paranoid. Believes spies are everywhere.
4. **Dalg.** Iron peg leg (burned off by magma). Flings spittle while talking. Tells loud stories of the duergar empire's glory days (centuries ago).
5. **Dardin.** Old, nattering. Bald pate. Chitters about how Dorgrim (duergar god) speaks to him in dreams and wants his eyes back.
6. **Falgrin.** Dark under-eye circles. Tired. Loathes iron tree fruit (Area 26).
7. **Gorbin.** Braided, white beard. Permanent frown. Wants Malik to teach him magic and tries extra hard to curry the efreet's favor.
8. **Gulrund.** Fat, ambling. Secretly catches and boils scorpions (tastes like crab). Will do anything for real food.
9. **Gundal.** Wide-eyed, totally silent. Communicates in hand gestures.
10. **Harvald.** Pale, bony. Grinds teeth. Berserk in combat (ADV on attacks).
11. **Hobb.** One eye much bigger than the other. The big eye has X-Ray vision through doors. Says it came from eating a magic fairy mushroom.
12. **Jagrid.** Burly, swaggering. Cowardly. DISADV on morale checks.
13. **Kulge.** Cheshire cat grin at all times. Claims falsely to know everyone's secrets. Does know, however, that Malik has a rakshasa servant.
14. **Megrim.** Clean, serious, dutiful. Descendant of Yorgrim, a duergar hero.
15. **Molrig.** Tattoos on shaved scalp. Puffed up, crashes around, bossy.
16. **Mordun.** Extremely pale. Long eyebrows. Chews on nuggets of iron ore.
17. **Norgrim.** Slick hair, short beard. Prim, formal. Megrim's younger brother.
18. **Pultrid.** Broken nose, face scars. Former pit fighter. +2 LV, +2 on attacks.
19. **Ravol.** Twitchy, haunted eyes. Whispers to self. Once saw something horrible in an underground lake (an aboleth). Wants to know if it was real.
20. **Theorin.** Old, grumbly, achy. Reluctant to do anything. Huffs and puffs.

# Join The Dark

## SHADOWDARK RPG COMMUNITY

Find other *Shadowdark RPG* players, Game Masters, and creators in The Arcane Library's **Discord** server! It's a friendly place to organize games, share ideas, and ask questions.

**Discord link:** <https://discord.gg/abPNTQmjG7>

Also, keep an eye out at gaming **conventions** for Shadowdark events and open tables!

Kelsey Dionne, *Shadowdark RPG*'s creator and head of The Arcane Library, runs open-table, unscheduled games at **Gary Con** each year. Come find where she's lurking and jump in!

You can also stay up-to-date on *Shadowdark RPG* happenings by joining the **newsletter**.

**Newsletter link:** <https://www.thearcanelibrary.com/pages/shadowdark-rpg-newsletter>

## FIND ADVENTURES AND CONTENT

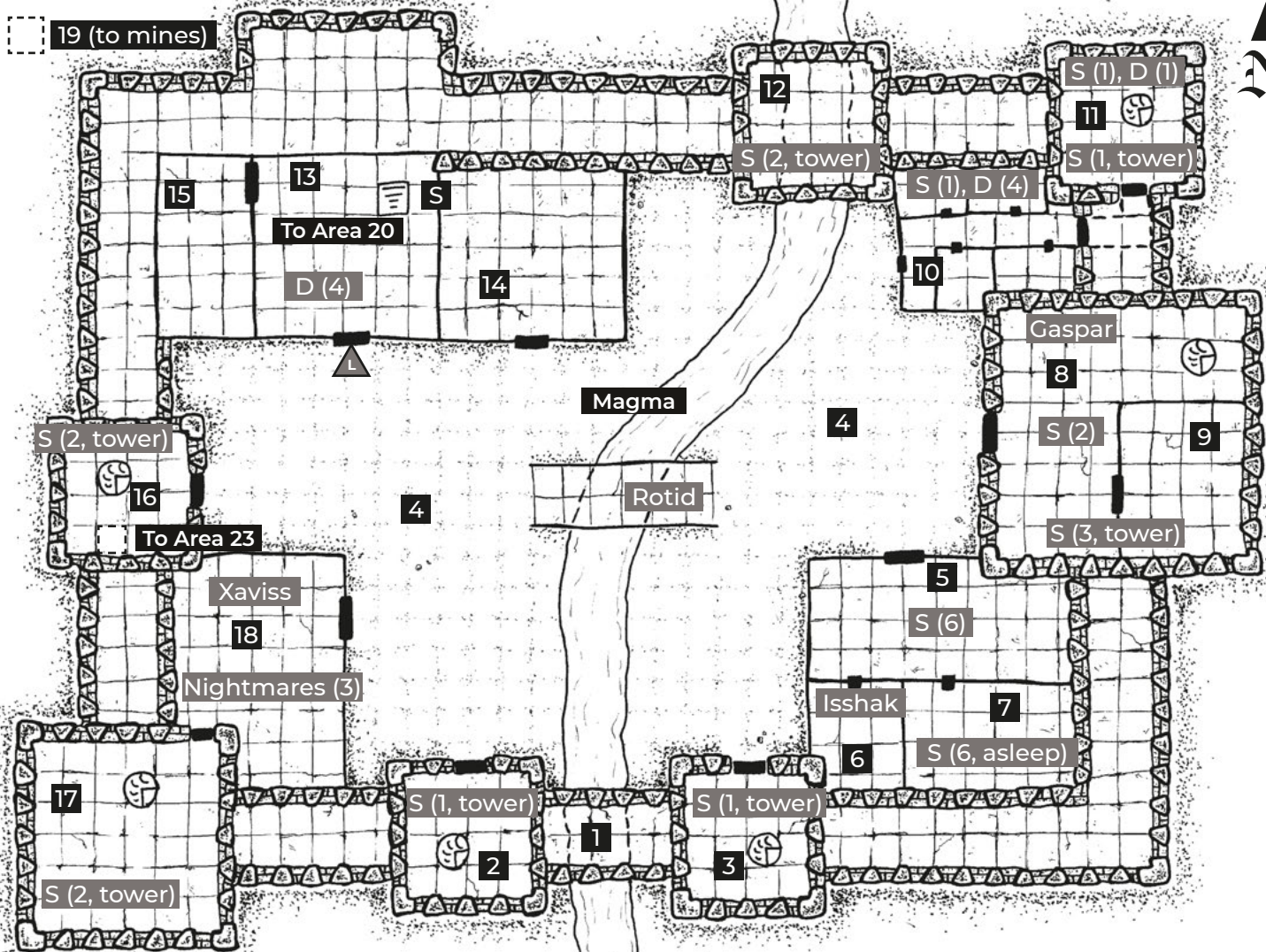
Visit **thearcanelibrary.com** for the latest in *Shadowdark RPG* adventures and articles.

There, you can grab print or PDF issues of ***Cursed Scroll***, the official Shadowdark zine bursting with themed character options, monsters, locations, and critically-acclaimed adventures.

Follow The Arcane Library on **[youtube.com/thearcanelibrary](https://youtube.com/thearcanelibrary)** for video guides, tips, tricks, and adventure walkthroughs!

Finally, spectacular **creators** such as Taylor Seely-Wright, Laurin-David Weggen, James Mishler, and Jake Savala (brewin\_druid) have published an amazing array of adventures, settings, character options and more under the Shadowdark RPG Third-Party License.

Check out their excellent work on [drivethrurpg.com](https://drivethrurpg.com) and [itch.io](https://itch.io)!



S Salamander  
D Duergar  
L Locked  
S Secret door (rotating panel)

S Salamander

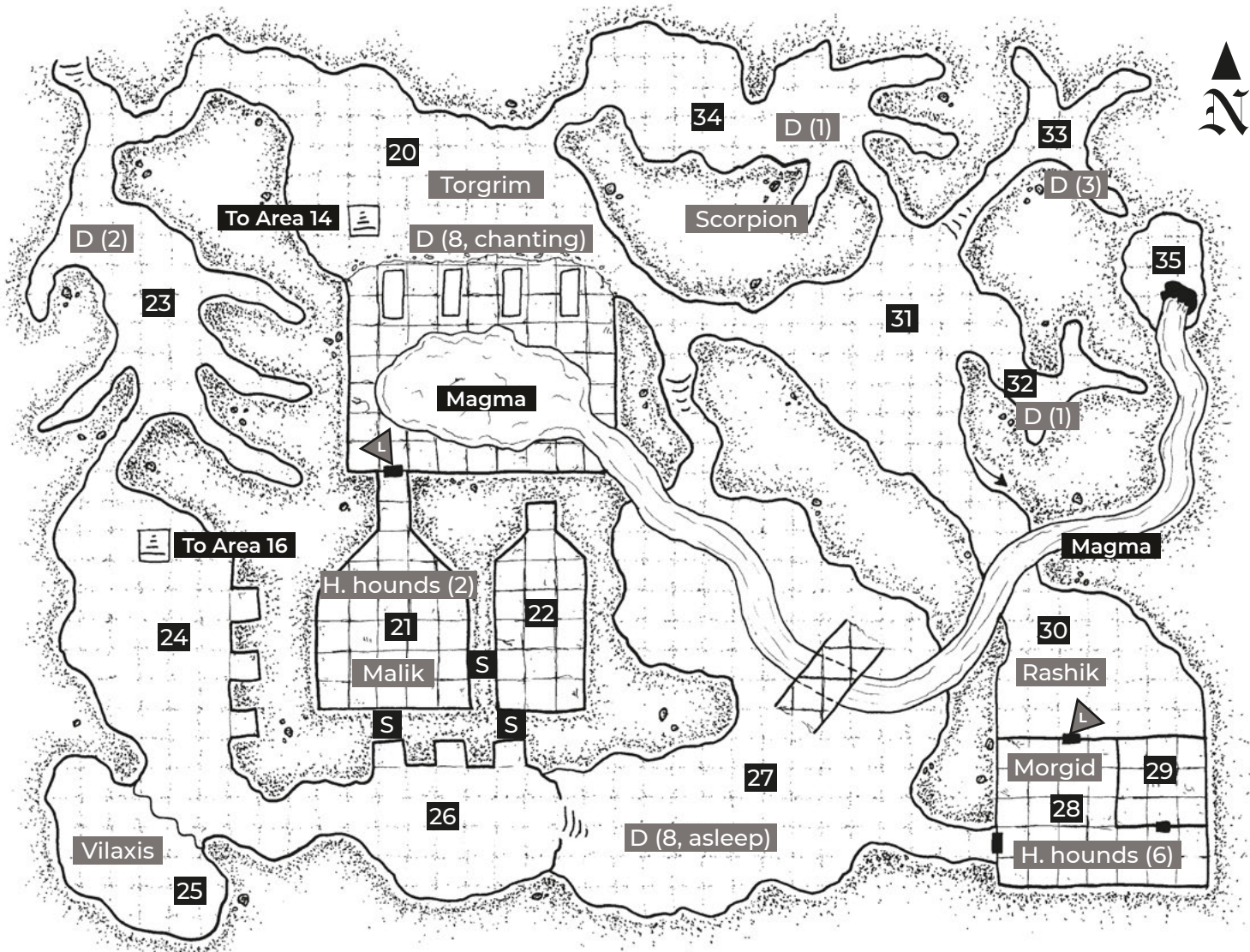
D Duergar

L

Locked

S

Secret door (rotating panel)



## IN A DEAD BANDIT'S HAND, YOU FIND...

### d20 Item

- |    |                                                                               |
|----|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1  | Cursed eye token; DISADV on next check or attack roll                         |
| 2  | Burlap bag tied shut with an angry cobra inside                               |
| 3  | Torn half of a treasure map; other half next time rolling this                |
| 4  | Sealed clay jar with, 1d4: <b>1-2.</b> 20 gp, <b>3-4.</b> scarab beetle swarm |
| 5  | Brass wine cup with secret reservoir that dispenses poison                    |
| 6  | Three trick dice weighted to roll, 1d4: <b>1-2.</b> high, <b>3-4.</b> low     |
| 7  | Invitation to a private pit fight at a powerful noble's palace                |
| 8  | A jade comb that, by law, forgives its bearer of one crime                    |
| 9  | Corked glass vial with a tiny, living scorpion inside it                      |
| 10 | Unopened bottle of exceptionally potent Murgazi wine                          |
| 11 | Scarab beetle token; ADV on next check or attack roll                         |
| 12 | Gold signet ring belonging to a noble family in Alkesh                        |
| 13 | Bag of 1d4 sweet dates that each heal 1 HP when eaten                         |
| 14 | Worm oil; pour in sand to attract a purple worm in 1d4 rds                    |
| 15 | Vial of poison, 1d4: <b>1-2.</b> common, <b>3.</b> uncommon, <b>4.</b> rare   |
| 16 | Tube with 1d4 phoenix plumes, work as waterproof matches                      |
| 17 | Ownership papers for a prized war horse stabled in Alkesh                     |
| 18 | Shard of blue glass that sometimes reflects brief portents                    |
| 19 | Bag of magic sesame seeds; sprinkle on a door to unlock it                    |
| 20 | Tarnished, bronze oil lamp carved with a faded inscription                    |



THE ARCANES LIBRARY

# ShadowDark



ISBN 979-8-9854564-4-8



9 798985 456448